EST 2023 | ISSUE 08 | DECEMBER 2024

Daily Trojan Magazine

COPY THAT, COPY DESK

Editors wrestle with the future of copy editing amid the rise of generative AI and newsroom layoffs.

BY DEON BOTSHEKAN, NICHOLAS CORRAL & FIONA FEINGOLD

JAKE BERG / DAILY TROJAN

TABLE of CONTENTS

COVER STORY

COPY THAT, COPY DESK, 24

BY DEON BOTSHEKAN, NICHOLAS CORRAL & FIONA FEINGOLD

THE REAL WORLD

HOUSTON, THE MEDIA HAS A PROBLEM, 18

BY JENNIFER NEHRER

YOBOSEYO: SMALL BUSINESS, BIG IMPACT, 46

BY ABBY WEILAND

THE STORIES SERVED WITH OUR MEALS, 10

BY LILAH KEATING

LA NIGHTS, 32

BY JAKE BERG

THE LONG READ

LA 2052, 34

BY DANIEL PONS

CULTURE

X-AMINING XBOX'S IDENTITY CRISIS, 6

BY SAMMY BOVITZ

GODZILLA VS. MY ATTENTION SPAN... FIGHT!, 14

BY SUNDIATA ENUKE

COMIC

GET BACK UP, 30

BY AMELIA NEILSON-SLABACH

DEDICATION

FOR MY GRANDFATHER — THE GREATEST STORYTELLER I'VE EVER KNOWN.

HAPPY 86TH BIRTHDAY!
HERE'S TO MANY MORE.

JAKE BERG / DAILY TROJAN

From the editor

There's something I find deeply unpalatable about going from 21 to 22. Twenty-one is such a coveted milestone — especially in the United States. Twenty-two, on the other hand, doesn't hold much significance to people beyond being a so-called "angel number" and the title of a popular Taylor Swift song. Neither of those things are particularly problematic, but I don't personally associate my 22nd birthday with either of the two. For me, turning 22 means one thing: It's time to decide what I'm doing after college. In case you were wondering — no, I don't want to do that.

For the first time in my life, I don't feel ready to get older. I don't want to face the "real world" or start my new life as a "proper adult." If I could wish for anything this year, I would ask for more time. Of course, I know that's not going to happen. My life is about to change whether I like it or not, so I'm trying to accept that sooner rather than later.

As I begin to mourn everything I'm about to leave behind at USC, I know by far the greatest loss will be saying goodbye to the people at the *Daily Trojan*.

I met most of the people at the paper just one or two years ago, but it feels like I've known them my whole life. They've made the most mundane days exciting and the most difficult days easy to overcome. I can't remember a time I've laughed more than I did during my late-night shifts at the News desk with my former co-editors **Nathan Elias** and **Jennifer Nehrer**. I don't quite know what that says about me, but I'm grateful for it regardless.

I frequently talk about how unhealthy it is to treat your coworkers like your "family" and your workplace like your "home," but I struggle every day to keep the newsroom

separate from my personal life. So many of my coworkers are also my closest friends, and I often don't know where I should be drawing the line. I'm not sure at all if I'm doing things the "right" way, but I can still say this for certain: Every day I spend in our newsroom is a day I spend with the people I love. It might make me a hypocrite, but I wouldn't trade it for the world.

The best parts of our newsroom would be impossible to replicate (believe me, I've tried). There's some sort of magic that can only exist on the fourth floor of the Wilson Student Union, and as much as I want to take it with me after I graduate, I know I can't.

It's painful to think about moving on, but it's a privilege to have something so special to lose in the first place. There are no words that can express how thankful I am that this paper has been a part of my life for the past four years.

As I prepare to step down from my position as the editor of the Magazine, I am overwhelmed with gratitude. It has been the honor of a lifetime to work alongside our chief Copy editors **Deon Botshekan** and **Fiona Feingold**; our director of Art & Design **Vivienne Tran**; our Photo editor **Henry Kofman**; our managing editor **Stefano Fendrich**; our digital managing editor **Nathan Elias**; our editor in chief **Kimberly Aguirre**; and the Magazine's 24 staff writers, who have truly exceeded all of my highest expectations this past semester.

Every month, they made the impossible come to life. Every day, they gave me a new reason to miss USC.

Sasha Ryu

Editor, Daily Trojan Magazine

Bryce Dechert / Daily Trojan file photo (modified)

X-amining Xbox's identity crisis

Does "X" even need "Box?"

BY SAMMY BOVITZ

Ally Marecek / Daily Trojan

There was a time when 2024 looked like a golden opportunity for Microsoft's Xbox. I've never considered getting its latest console, the Xbox Series X, but I still thought 2024 could be "the year of Xbox" as recently as March.

Let's set the scene. Sony, despite the success of the PlayStation 5, announced upfront that they would not release any big-budget exclusives this year — which is kind of like Disney announcing that they wouldn't be releasing any animated movies. Nintendo was in hibernation, awaiting the inevitable announcement of the Switch's successor. That left the market wide open for Microsoft to dominate with a slate of compelling Xbox exclusives and promising announcements.

And yet, 2024 is almost over, and it has not been the "year of Xbox." In fact, that prodigal year may never come. In order to understand what could lead Xbox to failure, we must first understand their biggest recent success.

FAST PASS

Xbox Game Pass, for the uninitiated, is essentially the video game equivalent of Netflix. I am perhaps the billionth person to make this comparison, but it's an effective one: The pay-per-month streaming service allows a consumer to stream a cavalcade of games across genres without owning them.

Game Pass launched in 2017 and has been a decent success thus far, with a player base of roughly 34 million subscribers. Its rival, PlayStation, has stopped sharing subscriber numbers for its service, PlayStation Plus — a fantastic sign for Microsoft.

There's just one problem. The Xbox Series X and S — the Series S, for our purposes, is just a cheaper and all-digital Series X — have only sold about 28 million units. Even if we assume every single person who bought a Series X or S also subscribes to Game Pass, we'd still have a discrepancy of six million users who don't have an Xbox Series X or S but subscribe to Game Pass anyway. Subscribers on Xbox One make up this difference somewhat, but the real strength of Xbox Game Pass may not even be on Xbox itself.

Trusted Reviews / Creative Commons

Xbox Game Pass for PC is exactly what it sounds like, and it's simultaneously a startling success for and a massive threat to Microsoft. While Xbox has declined to share the division of subscribers on its distinct platforms, it's intriguing that this PC service could be nearly as popular and profitable as the Xbox consoles themselves. If the Game Pass for PC is indeed that popular, an obvious question follows: Why even bother making consoles in the first place?

It doesn't help that Xbox has never been the market leader in the console space. The original Xbox was vanquished by the PlayStation 2, and while the Xbox 360 and PlayStation 3 were neck-and-neck throughout the seventh generation, the PS3 ultimately won out. Then came the last generation, where it wasn't even close; the PlayStation 4 won without breaking a sweat. As Series X sales continue to lag slightly behind the PlayStation 5, it's increasingly hard to justify the hardware.

But if Xbox's hardware could be doomed, there's one natural solution: software! All Xbox needs to justify its continued existence is a series of killer apps — and it're so close to this possibility that the reality is mind boggling.

STUDIO SETBACKS

Xbox Game Studios is one of the most valuable entertainment companies in the world. It might not seem like it, but a shopping spree Microsoft has been riding for nearly a decade has led to a staggering collection of talent and intellectual properties that they can exercise however they want.

The spree began back in the summer of 2018 when Xbox bought four studios and created a new one. Later, a duo of knockout punches landed as Xbox completed a $7.5 billion purchase of Bethesda Softworks in 2020, followed by the mammoth $68.7 billion purchase of Activision Blizzard in 2022. These studios are two of the biggest publishers on the planet, and they control some of the most iconic gaming franchises. Xbox buying both of them was seen as a huge power

move and a direct shot at Sony's otherwise dominant PlayStation brand.

However, it seems that these purchases have not yet borne fruit. The four studios bought in 2018 have combined to produce just three games in the years since its purchase. Bethesda finally debuted its first Xbox-exclusive game, "Starfield," in 2023. It was a hit, but it didn't even crack the top 10 on the year-end sales chart — a blow made even worse by the fact that PlayStation and Nintendo's tentpole games, "Marvel's Spider-Man 2" and "The Legend of Zelda: Tears of the Kingdom" both managed to make it in.

Xbox has a tough time succeeding with its own studios. This isn't a generalization — it's a near-constant reality.

Let's start with the studio that is supposed to be the most stable in its arsenal. The recently renamed Halo Studios run the — you guessed it — "Halo" franchise for Xbox, and the last few years for them have been worryingly newsworthy.

The last entry in the series, the 2021 entry "Halo Infinite," is infamous for its rocky development history: In the span of less than a year, three different directors left or were fired. A wave of layoffs and the abandonment of the studio's in-house game engine snowballed into a complete "internal reboot," which included the name change. While Halo Studios are now trending in the right direction, they took a long road to get there.

Xbox also seems to repel some of its best studios from success. Tango Gameworks, a Bethesda studio previously known for making spooky games like "Ghostwire: Tokyo," shocked the industry in 2023 with its breakout rhythm-action hit "Hi-Fi Rush." However, just a year and some change later, Xbox announced the studio would shut down. That studio would later be resuscitated under third-party publisher Krafton, but the sting of that decision remains.

Then there's Toys for Bob, an Activision subsidiary that Xbox bought in 2022. The "Skylanders" team reached new heights in 2018 with a vivid remake of the iconic "Spyro" trilogy of platforming action games, then delighted longtime gamers everywhere with the 2020 legacy sequel "Crash Bandicoot 4: It's About Time." After just one original game, "Crash Team Rumble," the studio abruptly announced it was spinning off from Xbox earlier this year.

Trusted Reviews / Creative Commons

Both of those studios have retained some partnerships with Xbox, but it's hard to tell what that will mean, exactly — and it would be hard to blame the studios if they didn't end up meaning much.

Activision Blizzard, the expensive crown jewel of Xbox Game Studios nowadays, is doing well — but it is extremely vulnerable if sales go south. Its valuation is almost entirely based around one series, "Call of Duty," which is so ridiculously popular that Xbox had to promise to keep the series on PlayStation platforms in order to even buy the company in the first place.

A series that began under just one team, Infinity Ward, has now expanded to encompass a staggering six studios — nearly the entirety of Activision. As long as "Call of Duty" remains a gigantic gaming franchise, this is not a problem. But if gamers start to get the "Call of Duty" equivalent of superhero fatigue, what then?

It's not over yet for Xbox's studios, and it appears that plenty of big games are ahead of them. New entries in series like "Fable," "Perfect Dark" and "Gears of War" are on the way. But if the studio can't get those teams to stick around, let alone release great games, Game Pass and the Xbox itself may become an increasingly difficult proposition for the average consumer.

THE FUTURE(S)

As far as I can tell, this means that Xbox can follow two paths towards a viable and successful future. One is far more boring than the other.

First, the boring timeline: Xbox stays on its current trajectory, skirting

the line between console publisher and eccentric game distributor. It continues to manage its massive acquisitions, Bethesda and Activision Blizzard, as just another aspect of its business. Xbox Game Pass subscriptions become increasingly more important than consoles sold, but Microsoft doesn't fully commit to prioritizing either profit model. Disgruntled studios continue to come and go, with shutdowns, reboots and the occasional hit breaking through. It's a profitable enough business, but there might be a hard ceiling on its business model's growth.

There is an alternative here, and while it would undoubtedly be bizarre, I don't think it's completely out of the question. Xbox has the potential to beat its own acquisitions to become the biggest third-party publisher on the planet by far, while simultaneously remaining a major platform — without producing any more Xboxes.

Game Pass can absolutely become its central product. Because it's a subscription service with hundreds of first-party games guaranteed to remain on there, it can beat PC marketplaces like Steam and console subscriptions like PlayStation Plus to become the definitive best deal in gaming.

Xbox's library is huge after acquiring Bethesda and Activision Blizzard, and without any pesky console specs or release timelines holding it back, Xbox can offer 20 years of gaming history on one platform seamlessly. Free from hardware exclusivity, it can even license out Game Pass compatibility to hardware competitors like Apple TV or even — dare I say it? — the Nintendo Switch.

But that's just one part of this new model. Now that Xbox owns Bethesda and Activision Blizzard as well as a slew of other studios, it can start publishing full time on PlayStation and Nintendo platforms and overtake its exclusives to become the biggest company on its rivals' own systems. Imagine how embarrassing it would be for a "Halo" game to outsell a "Mario" game on a Nintendo console — but the only outcome more mortifying for Nintendo would be to reject the game from its store, almost certainly losing out on millions.

"Xbox has the potential to beat its own acquisitions to become the biggest third-party publisher ... without producing any more Xboxes."

Xbox is already testing the waters of this option. Earlier this year, it captivated the gaming industry by announcing that four of its smaller first-party games would come to PlayStation 5 and Nintendo Switch. Two huge upcoming Bethesda games, "Indiana Jones and the Great Circle" and "DOOM: The Dark Ages," are coming to the PS5 as well. With the "Call of Duty" deal locked in as well, there's no reason for Microsoft to not go all in on software with its resources.

It's not like Xbox needs to completely leave the hardware space, either. It can keep supporting the Series X and sell as many as it can before the supply runs dry. Xbox controllers remain popular as well, and loyalists would surely jump for Xbox controllers to play alongside their Game Pass subscriptions.

Xbox head Phil Spencer said back in 2022 that Xbox loses hundreds on every console it sells, and it has to hope it makes the money back with games and accessories. So, what's the point?

If it can keep making "X" millions of dollars, it might not need the "Box" part.

Wikimedia Commons / Creative Commons

Sammy Bovitz is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and an assistant editor and columnist for the *Daily Trojan*'s Arts & Entertainment section, penning the biweekly column "Boardrooms & Blockbusters." Bovitz is a sophomore majoring in journalism.

News on the side: the stories served with our meals

USC's dining hall TVs offer a mix of channels; do they simply entertain, or do they subtly shape perceptions?

BY LILAH KEATING

køpper / Flickr

I never really paid attention to the TVs in the dining halls. The flashing screens displaying sports, news stations and random television shows couldn't hold my attention as much as my friends, my phone or my wandering thoughts. That is until one afternoon.

Around lunchtime Sept. 9, I decided to use one of my two weekly swipes at Tutor Campus Center. As I took a seat facing a television screen the size of a hot tub, I realized my phone was dead — so I might as well watch whatever was on. Projected in front of me was the headline, "Lies and Vibes: The Harris Campaign." Taking a second look, I noticed it was Fox News, reporting on a speech Kamala Harris would give the next day. The station speculated that she would lie about Trump encouraging violence, misrepresent his comments on Charlottesville and exaggerate lawsuits against him.

Later that day, I went to McCarthy dining hall for dinner. Once again, the TV nearest to me caught my eye, but this time it was playing CNN. The screen read, "Harris prepares for showdown she's long sought with Trump as he takes a more informal approach." The two stations clearly had opposing viewpoints on the same candidate, framing Harris through wildly different lenses.

The same pattern repeated the following day but at different dining halls. This time, I ate lunch at Everybody's Kitchen and dinner at Parkside Restaurant. At EVK, the featured Fox News criticized Harris's speech, while CNN at Parkside applauded her performance. It struck me that where I randomly decided to

eat that day shaped what I saw and potentially how I perceived this event.

After that, I started paying attention to the TVs scattered across dining halls and noticed the variety of programs they played: a range of news stations, professional and collegiate sports, the occasional TV show, weather forecasts and sometimes just music. This observation raised questions: How are these channels chosen, and do students even notice what they're watching?

HOW ARE CHANNELS SELECTED?

To understand how stations are chosen, I reached out to USC Hospitality. Their answer was surprisingly simple: "The televisions in the dining halls are randomly set on various channels."

Each day, the dining hall staff turn the TVs on, selecting channels arbitrarily. There is no strict policy, and students can even request a channel be changed.

In an email to the *Daily Trojan*, a University spokesperson reaffirmed what USC Hospitality shared in their statement.

"We can assure you: There is no omnipotent force determining which station is on at Parkside or any other residence hall," the spokesperson wrote. "USC does not have a magic remote that is turning the channels to stations you dislike or like … I am not sure which channel you prefer or if there are some that bother [you] or your friends more than others. It is entirely up to you to ask [sic]."

The spokesperson went on to add "TV stations do not represent the university."

This random method of channel selection opens up a broader conversation. For most, the TVs might just be background noise, adding ambiance to a bustling dining hall. But if students do pay attention, could the information displayed subtly influence their perceptions of events or even reinforce biases?

TVS IN PASSING

To gauge this, I interviewed USC students at the dining halls for their TV takeaways.

"I feel like it's usually a mix of sports, random TV channels, or like the news," said Sara Kim, a freshman majoring in law, history and culture.

Kim's friend, Hailey Wilson, a freshman law, history and culture major, has had a similar experience.

"Mostly looked at it on election day. Other times it's not really noticeable," Wilson said.

Wilson said she paid attention on election day because the TVs were "showing the results as it progressed," but she doesn't remember which station was playing.

Tej Kollu, a freshman majoring in neuroscience, shared that he generally pays the most attention to the televisions when they're playing sports.

"When I'm by myself, I'll watch TV. It's usually a lot of sports, like basketball for fall, sometimes NFL," Kollu said.

While Kollu occasionally notices the news playing, he admits that when it comes to identifying specific stations, he doesn't pay attention.

"To be honest, I couldn't tell you. I just noticed the news," Kolu said.

This seems to be the consensus: students occasionally glance at the screens, skimming headlines or watching the sports highlights, but rarely pay attention to which station is playing. Most aren't aware of the potential biases embedded in the programs — or the fact that the random channels they're watching could be promoting a specific narrative, subtly shaping a story to fit a particular agenda.

THE MEDIA'S SUBCONSCIOUS INFLUENCE

It's easy to dismiss the dining hall TVs as mere background noise. But consider this: For students like me, who rarely stop to think about the news they're passively consuming, these screens can become a subtle but persistent influence. The randomness of channel selection means that students might see two completely different versions of the same story depending on the day and dining hall.

This randomness is not inherently harmful — after all, variety exposes students to diverse perspectives. But without awareness or critical engagement, it's also possible to internalize biased narratives without realizing it. In fact, a Pew Research Center study

kopper / Flickr

from 2021 found that 60% of Americans thought misinformation from the 2020 election had a significant impact on the election results.

In an age of an information surplus, media literacy is more essential than ever. While dining hall TVs might seem inconsequential, they reflect the broader issue of how we consume media in public spaces. Regardless of their slant, news channels shape narratives that influence public opinion. For students at a university like USC, which prides itself on encouraging critical thinking, it's crucial to recognize and question the biases in the information we encounter, even in casual settings like the dining halls.

LOOKING BEYOND THE SCREEN

The dining hall TVs serve as more than mere entertainment to enhance the dining experience. They're a reminder of how easily we consume information without questioning its source or framing. What we do and don't see shapes our understanding of events, making this especially important during critical moments like a presidential election.

The randomness of the channel selection in our dining halls mirrors a larger media landscape that is also unpredictable — diverse, yet profoundly influential. By paying attention to what we're watching, we can shift passive consumption into active engagement. In a world where headlines often carry as much weight as the stories they introduce, this small shift in awareness could make all the difference.

Lilah Keating is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine. Keating is a freshman majoring in business administration.

Teo Gonzales / Daily Trojan

Jordan Renville / Daily Trojan file photo

GODZILLA VS. MY ATTENTION SPAN ... FIGHT!

Understanding media overconsumption as censorship 70 years post-Gojira.

BY SUNDIATA ENUKE

Jude Awadallah / Daily Trojan

Lewis Ogden / flickr

Growing up, I wasn't allowed to watch TV on weekdays, even during the summer. Still, when my family had gone to sleep, I'd sneak into the kitchen and precariously climb onto a tall wooden stool so I could reach the height of our countertop Toshiba.

I'd push the power on button with as much precision as I could muster, but still — zzzz — the quiet crackle of the TV warming up was enough to make me look over each shoulder twice. Before settling in, I skillfully balanced on tiptoes, with arms stretched for that familiar yellow box of sugary goodness atop the fridge. Then, finally, wrapped in a princess blanket, I sat, eyes glued to the glowing screen, crunching on an overfilled bowl of Honey Bunches of Oats.

At six, I was first introduced to Ishirô Honda and his spectacular world of monsters. "Destroy All Monsters" (1968), like other Godzilla movies, was featured on the Turner Classic Movies channel. I still remember the moment I saw the glittering characters appear over an orange sunset: "Destroy All Monsters."

At the time, I felt like an adult watching a real monster movie instead of the usual "Camp Rock" (2008). There, I made my first astute cinematic analysis: the red, blue and green military base looked like the PlayPlace at McDonald's, the she-alien race, Kilaaks, were creepy, and the yellow spandex space suits were cool as hell. Mix that with a plot to take over the world and a giant goofy lizard? I was in.

As I watched the movie, one question stuck in my mind from the initial narration: If the Kaiju — giant monsters in Japanese — were never freed by the Kilaak, would they have stayed trapped in Monsterland — the high-tech remote island built to trap them — forever? The scientists gave them all the fish they could eat, and the barriers were designed to withstand the Kaiju's greatest attempts to escape. Wouldn't they have gotten tired eventually? Given up? The island seemed pretty nice, and, me personally, I — King Ghidorah is slammed to the ground by Godzilla — WOAHHHHH!!

Years passed, and "Destroy All Monsters" became a kitschy lost world of my childhood. It was tucked away collecting dust along with my princess blanket and my mild addiction to dry Honey Bunches of Oats. Long past were the days of late-night kitchen screenings of the Classics channel. I got my first taste of the internet in elementary school when my parents purchased an iMac desktop computer. Then I got my first smartphone in fifth grade, and as my access to media became whenever and wherever I wanted, I couldn't bring myself to care about Godzilla's next level up or increasingly menacing foe. None of it compared to the terror I could access at my fingertips.

I went from sneaking TV time on the weekdays to a constant stream of media during my waking hours. As soon as I wake up, I listen to the news to get myself up to date. Then, I scroll on TikTok for a bit, see four to five edits about BRAT-coded Kamala Harris and homoerotic edits of Donald Trump and Joe Biden set to Chappell Roan's "Casual," followed by a video detailing the devastation in Gaza — back to BRAT summer. I listen to Kendrick Lamar in the shower. A YouTube video essay with my breakfast. A podcast for my walk to class where we watch a three-hour noir from the 1950s — jeez, my attention span is messed up.

Class ends. In my headphones, I blast Doechii all the way back to the dorms. Over dinner, I watch a couple of episodes of my show

of the week — yes, I go through a show a week. I doomscroll on TikTok a bit more before starting my homework, listen to jazz in the shower and then go to sleep with the consoling whispers of an ASMRtist making some strange concoction called Wood Soup or roleplaying a 16th-century doctor treating me for the bubonic plague.

I indulge in media from all directions, and slowly but surely, my capacity to truly engage and think about the content I'm reading, watching and hearing dwindles to nothing. I am simply consuming. Just as my attention splinters, the Godzilla franchise morphs to match the changing demands of a constantly overstimulated audience.

Throughout the years, Godzilla has taken 44 different forms across 44 films. The 1970s saw a funky, psychedelic, almost avant-garde Godzilla in "Godzilla vs. Hedorah" (1971). "All Monsters Attack" (1969) prioritizes physical comedy and is told through the perspective of a young boy as fan demographics shifted to younger audiences. "Shin Godzilla" (2016) features a hyper-realistic depiction of the monster. Bug eyes, countless rows of razor-sharp teeth piled in its mouth and thick black scales with crevices that expose deep red muscle. A style akin to "District 9" (2009), a reflection of the grotesque apocalyptic monster movies of the late 2010s. Over the last 70 years, Godzilla has paid close attention to what the people want, starting from the original "Gojira" (1954).

The original "Gojira" was a horror film — not an action blockbuster or slapstick comedy with a latex-suited Kaiju. Honda, the writer and director of the original film, served in World War II and saw the rubble of Hiroshima upon his return to Japan. Horrified by the devastation of war, Honda wanted to reflect the anxieties of the time and point a mirror in the face of Japanese bureaucracy.

Released to the public in Japan Nov. 3, 1954, audiences reacted not with laughter or with expressive fear, as Honda intended, but with pain. Japanologist and author William Tsutsui emphasized the significance of Godzilla's first audience — the people who witnessed the destruction of Tokyo in 1945. In "Gojira," viewers witnessed the decimation of a city that, in reality, was still being pieced back together. It was a traumatic hit. For the citizens of Tokyo, this was far from fiction.

Rawpixel

Post Hiroshima and Nagasaki, fear engulfed Japan. Anxieties were high, and questions about the long-term effects of exposure to radiation pervaded. "Hibakusha" — a Japanese term used to refer to the surviving victims of atomic warfare — faced immense discrimination and alienation from the rest of the population.

In 1945, rumors that radiation exposure could spread from one person to another, like an infectious disease, were widely accepted as fact. After surviving an unimaginable trauma, survivors were neglected by the very institutions and communities that were supposed to protect them. The Hibakusha were shunned by their own neighbors and even made ineligible for employment and marriage.

In a dark theater, almost 10 years after what many call the "unforgettable fire," Gojira's shriek broke Japan's painful silence. The monster uprooted what was considered taboo at the time and connected with the civilian victims' deep loss and guilt.

Seventy years later, the film's content still rings true, but unlike earlier generations, Gen Z consumes without pausing. This threatens to leave us uninterested and detached from what we care about most. Whether Godzilla was fighting off aliens, a robot version of himself or every Kaiju ever created, I didn't care. Once, the idea of Monsterland fascinated me to no end, but as the years went by, I struggled to keep my focus on any Godzilla film, no matter the outlandish premise.

Revisiting "Destroy All Monsters" at 18 reminded me of what I lost. That silver screen held all my attention and care at a time, even when I was away from it. An hour and a half of monsters and a full bowl of crunchy granola cereal was all I needed for weeks of self-questioning, pondering about the world and wondering about my place in it as a kid among monstrous forces. That very cage of comfort I once questioned is the place I find myself now.

Our generation's constant consumption of media is our Monsterland. We are fed here with all the entertainment we could want. The barriers of our media cycles have adapted to us. With each scroll, new series, next episode and outrageous edit, we get close to silencing our inklings of reflection. We numb the questions that pervade our minds about the world around us and fill every silence. We refuse to think too much. We refuse to lean into grief or loss. We pretend this remote island is home.

Escaping from Monsterland is as simple as acknowledging what I knew at six years old. If you sit with a Godzilla film, I mean really sit with it, you can see it. Beyond the many forms, hyper-commercialization or psychedelic aesthetics, Godzilla has a soul. That allegorical intuition that makes war Godzilla's only true adversary and moral lessons that reveal themselves if you take the time to question.

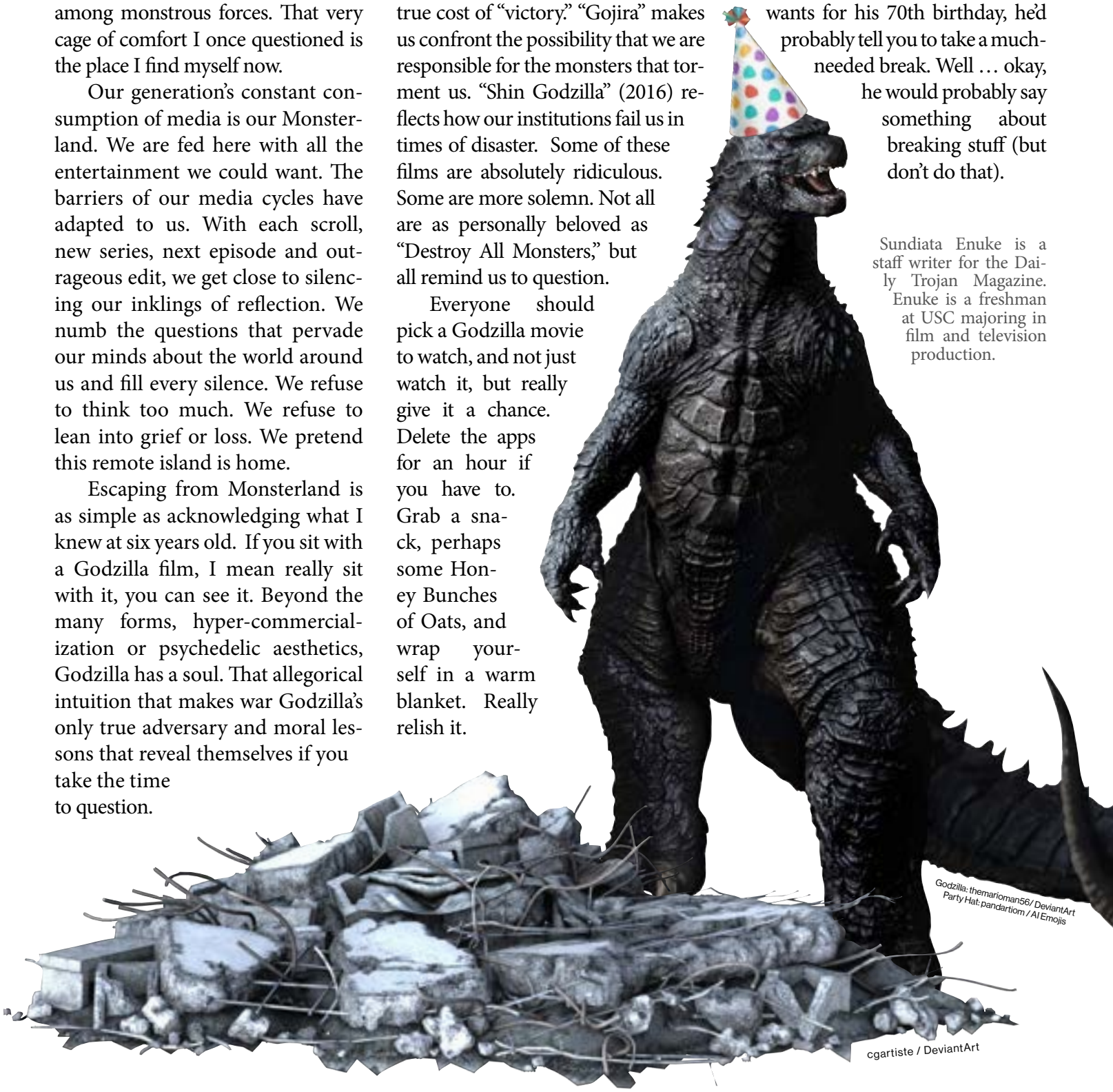
No, "Godzilla vs. Mechagodzilla" (1974) isn't just about fighting a robotic clone, but a face-off between nature and advancing technology that makes us question our control over our creations. Yes, "Godzilla: Final Wars" (2004) is the sequential battle between Godzilla and every kaiju ever created, but its town-by-town destruction makes us question the true cost of "victory." "Gojira" makes us confront the possibility that we are responsible for the monsters that torment us. "Shin Godzilla" (2016) reflects how our institutions fail us in times of disaster. Some of these films are absolutely ridiculous. Some are more solemn. Not all are as personally beloved as "Destroy All Monsters," but all remind us to question.

Everyone should pick a Godzilla movie to watch, and not just watch it, but really give it a chance. Delete the apps for an hour if you have to. Grab a snack, perhaps some Honey Bunches of Oats, and wrap yourself in a warm blanket. Really relish it.

When the movie finally has your full attention, don't let it go so easily. Reflect for a week, or two weeks or a lifetime. Take a break to remind yourself of what you've lost to constant consumption. The space to ponder. The freedom to think. The world outside the constraints of Monsterland.

If you asked Godzilla what he wants for his 70th birthday, he'd probably tell you to take a much-needed break. Well … okay, he would probably say something about breaking stuff (but don't do that).

Sundiata Enuke is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine. Enuke is a freshman at USC majoring in film and television production.



Godzilla: themarioman56/ DeviantArt
Party Hat: pandartiom / AI Emojis

cgartiste / DeviantArt

Houston, the media has a problem

Journalism is already losing. It will lose more under Donald Trump.

BY JENNIFER NEHRER

Bella Hoffman / Daily Trojan

Content warning: *This article contains mentions of violence and sexual assault.*

It is Nov. 9, 2016, and I wake up for school at 7 a.m. after going to sleep just six hours earlier, an anxious mess. I checked my phone and confirmed: Donald Trump will be the 45th president of the United States. I am fearful for myself and so many others because I have heard what he says about anyone who isn't like him: white, cishet, conservative and Christian.

It is Nov. 9, 2024, and I am writing this article. It has been three days since I woke up to the same news: Donald Trump will be the 47th president of the U.S. I am again fearful for myself and so many others for many more reasons than before. He and the Republican party have managed a sweep of the country's governing bodies and paved the way for the institution of Project 2025.

There are too many policies and projects I anticipate Trump and his government to implement to speak of in one article, and with so many of them, I can and will admit I am not an expert on all of his promises. What I know I can speak better on, and what I also fear deeply for, is the future of journalism under the second Trump administration.

In (Mild) Defense of Journalism

It would be hard to count how many times I have been asked by, presumably, well-meaning people about how I feel about joining a field that is either getting overtaken by artificial intelligence, social media, other technology or sensationalism.

Years ago, when I was a budding high school journalist and intensely defensive of my chosen profession — yes, I knew that early — I responded to these questions with a fervent testimony on its behalf. I had so many idols in journalism, and I was absolutely awestruck at its power. Truly, the profession could do no wrong.

I am so much less sure of that now.

To be fair, I am still awestruck by the power of journalism. The difference between then and now is I have seen how it can be used for good and evil. I still love journalism, and I am still intent on joining

the free press when I leave USC, but I have to acknowledge its flaws — and there are many.

The first issue is one I have spent years of my life researching and writing about: the Local News Crisis. Summarizing this issue in just a few sentences is difficult but necessary. I wrote in a Daily Trojan Magazine article earlier this year that the U.S. is on track to have lost a full third of all of its newspapers by the end of 2024. I also wrote that over one half of the counties in the U.S. have only one local news source, and as of last December, 228 of those counties were put on a watchlist by the Local News Initiative at the Northwestern University Medill School of Journalism to lose said source.

The Local News Crisis has significant ties to the second issue at hand: a massive misinformation crisis. This crisis generally can be attributed to a few sources. For one, local papers are generally found to be more politically neutral than national networks such as FOX News or even MSNBC.

Profiting off of the "attention economy," as coined by Emily Bell, the director of Columbia University's Tow Center for Digital Journalism, these networks and social media platforms will keep pushing any sensationalist or polarizing content that gets them clicks or views. The masses come back for more, the content keeps being pushed, and the cycle continues.

Of course, when people notice this and become opposed to the practice, they will — or might — turn against the media and their trust in it will waver. This is a dangerous game to play when public trust in the media is already very low.

In October 2024, Gallup reported the percentage of Americans who say they have a good amount of trust in the media had fallen to just 31%, and the percentage of those who said they don't trust the media "very much" or at all have been steadily rising — to 33 and 36% respectively — since between 2018 and 2020, with a brief exception for "not at all" between 2023 and 2024.

When the numbers are broken down by party, a dramatic gap appears. In 2024, just 12% of Republicans said they trust the media "a great deal/fair amount," whereas 54% of Democrats said the same. Independents landed somewhere in the middle at 27%. A similar split is found between age groups, where the younger the respondent was, the lower their trust wasis in the media.

I can think of a few current reasons for the drop in public trust, but the one I want to focus on is the man this country just elected to be the next president.

An Issue of Presidential Caliber

Gallup reported 40% of Americans trusted the media a fair amount in 2015. In 2016, as Trump's first campaign ran its course, it dropped to 32%. For Republicans specifically, the percentage fell from 32 to 14. There are a few different reasons to point fingers at the president-elect when it comes to sabotaging public trust in the news media. For one, it has been a frequent punching bag of his. Freedom House's 2017 report on the state of press freedom around the world painted a damning picture of how he thinks of and treats any media he doesn't like.

On the bottom of one page in the report, a quote from Trump is spotlit: "I have a running war with the media. They are among the most dishonest human beings on earth."

During his first presidency, the Trump White House went multiple long stretches without a single press briefing, something that is supposed to happen daily. POLITICO reported that at one point, the daily press briefings became opportunities for then-Press Secretary Kayleigh McEnany to chastise reporters for coverage the administration didn't like.

On the campaign trail for what will be term number two, Trump levied threats against the media to the tune of imprisoning journalists and stripping networks of their licenses. In 2022, he joked at multiple rallies that after throwing journalists and their editors in jail for not revealing their sources on certain matters, they would comply with the threat of prison rape.

At a rally just before Election Day, Trump said he wouldn't mind if a would-be assassin shot a member of the "fake news."

"I have this piece of glass here. But all we have really over here is the fake news, right? And to get me, somebody

Rene Ramos / DeviantArt

fake news," Trump said in Lititz, Pennsylvania, on Nov. 3. "And I don't mind that so much. I don't mind."

A report by the International Women's Media Foundation in 2024 has an entire section dedicated to what it calls "the Trump Effect," which in part details how his followers have responded to his attacks on the news media. It opens with the harrowing experience of a photojournalist who was covering a Trump rally when he pointed at the press area and declared they were "the enemy of the people."

"She and the other journalists were shocked, but before they had a chance to process his words, the crowd began spitting at them and trying to grab their press badges and camera straps," the report read. "After the event, the journalists were escorted to their cars by event security."

This opening anecdote is one of many the section shares, including a man who stormed the press area at a Pennsylvania rally after Trump criticized CNN and a tense interaction on the stage of the 2024 National Association of Black Journalists' Annual Convention & Career Fair, where he ripped into moderator and ABC News correspondent Rachel Scott. He called Scott and her question "nasty," "rude," "hostile" and "a disgrace" when she asked how he could win back Black voters after he called Black journalists and politicians "losers" and "animals."

"During a recent Trump rally in Pennsylvania," the report read, "a white male reporter was approached by someone wearing a t-shirt that said, 'Journalist. Rope. Tree. Some assembly required,' a clear, menacing reference to lynching, intended to intimidate journalists covering the event."

Commands Will Come from the Oval Office

In the early hours of Nov. 6, it became clear Trump would win the Electoral College and the popular vote, and that Republicans would retake the Senate. Just over a week later, networks began projecting that Republicans would take the House of Representatives as well.

Trump will have far more leeway to institute the policies he pleases. He will control the executive and legislative branches, and with a 6-3 majority on a court where several members are in their 60s and 70s, he will likely shape the judicial branch for the next few decades. His cabinet picks demonstrate that he wants his yes-men close by.

In the final days immediately before the election, we saw two media giants — *The Washington Post* and the *Los Angeles Times* — pull their punches. Both papers pulled already-written endorsements for Kamala Harris weeks before the election, with the *L.A. Times*' owner saying they did so to not increase already-present polarization in the country.

In the case of the former, a post on the social platform X from owner and e-commerce mogul Jeff Bezos confirmed one of my fears: Corporate media owners are becoming complacent when the media is needed the most.

"Big congratulations to our 45th and now 47th President on an extraordinary political comeback and decisive victory," he wrote. "No nation has bigger opportunities. Wishing @realDonaldTrump all success in leading and uniting the America we all love."

Naturally, he posted this after writing in an op-ed published by his paper that a planned endorsement of Kamala Harris would have continued a pattern of endorsements that he wrote, created a "perception of bias" for the paper. But this post is fine. Sure.

Speaking of X, its owner, Elon Musk, has generated his own share of controversies surrounding his destruction of the platform, various types and degrees of bigotry, and his close association with the president-elect.

Many essays could be written on the many ways Musk's purchase and control of the platform have been an absolute trainwreck, but I want to focus on his attitudes toward and treatment of the media on the platform.

A few months after he bought the platform, Musk began labeling the accounts of networks such as NPR "state-affiliated media," a term previously used for networks run by their governments such as RT in Russia. Sometime shortly after it was given the label, reporters at Forbes discovered that the terms for a "state-affiliated media" label on then-Twitter's website had been altered to omit an explicit

Rene Ramos / DeviantArt

exemption for NPR from this term because it maintains editorial independence.

As a result, some news organizations — including NPR — left the platform in the following weeks for similar reasons. NPR cited the label it had been given and the subsequent strategy to maintain its image as a credible news organization without a tainting label; PBS had the same label issue and came to the same conclusion. LAist, Hawaii Public Radio and WBUR — NPR's Boston affiliate — all left in a show of solidarity toward NPR.

Recently, on Nov. 13, *The Guardian* announced it would also be leaving X because it was concerned about the spread of far-right conspiracy theories, racism and the way the platform handled coverage of the presidential election.

"The US presidential election campaign served only to underline what we have considered for a long time: that X is a toxic media platform and that its owner, Elon Musk, has been able to use its influence to shape political discourse," *The Guardian* said in an announcement.

Musk has now been tapped by Trump to co-lead the new "Department of Government Efficiency," a name that is all but confirmed by Musk himself to be a nod to a cryptocurrency named after the "Doge" meme.

Potential and Pervasive Pet Projects

Now that Trump will hold office, there is a well-known — or should be well-known — policy plan he may be adopting: Project 2025.

Project 2025, developed by the conservative think tank The Heritage Foundation, is a 922-page document written by several people who worked in Trump's first administration — and some who still work for him. It outlines what the foundation thinks the next Republican president should do when in office, and it is a doozy.

A necessary disclaimer here is that we do not, at this moment, know if Trump will adopt any of Project 2025. He distanced himself from it on the campaign trail even as Democrats continuously pegged it as a hallmark of his then-potential administration. Perhaps this is because Tthe Heritage Foundation had submitted a different project to the first Trump administration and then said in 2018 that over 60% of their suggestions — including leaving the Paris Climate Accords — had been adopted.

It also could be because senior Heritage Foundation advisor and former director of the White House Presidential Personnel Office under Trump, John McEntee, said a lot of the Foundation's work will be "integrated" into the administration once again. Nevertheless, we should be prepared for what could happen. And for journalists, what could happen is disastrous.

Project 2025 advises on a wide range of subjects, from abortion to federal agencies to immigration, but most relevant to this article is its guidelines on the press. The document suggests several items that would significantly limit the ability of the free press to do its job, including potentially kicking journalists out of the White House.

Project 2025 also seeks to limit journalists' freedom to protect their sources and seek them out, as authors recommend the next president should direct their administration to pull no punches when investigating journalists who retrieve information from government sources. This particular guidance is written by Dustin Carmack, former chief of staff to Trump-era Director of National Intelligence John Ratcliffe and current director of public policy in the southern and southeastern U.S. . . . at Meta, who owns Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp.

Project 2025 also suggests that publicly funded media, such as PBS and NPR, should be stripped of its funding. Contrary to what section author and former *The Wall Street Journal* editorialist Mike Gonzalez seems to imply in his writing, NPR and PBS do not get their money directly from the government, as is the purpose of the Corporation for Public Broadcasting.

CPB was created by the government in the Public Broadcasting Act of 1967 and has been the middleman ever since. The corporation gets the money and decides how it wants to split it between every single one of its members. Also, the amount of money allotted to the organization is minuscule, constituting just

0.01% of the total federal budget.

Gonzalez notes, "Every Republican President since Richard Nixon has tried to strip the Corporation for Public Broadcasting (CPB) of taxpayer funding," and to finally do so would be "good policy and good politics." The stated concern is an apparent worry that continuous funding would result in a BBC-like network funded by the government. Personally, I don't think an amount totaling $1.33 per US citizen split between dozens of networks will do that.

It is also worth noting that less than 1% of NPR's current budget comes from CPB — and other agencies' — grants. Again, not exactly an amount that will buy you influence. It is, however, an avenue NPR says is critical to maintain its status quo. In their own words: "Elimination of federal funding would result in fewer programs, less journalism— especially local journalism —and eventually the loss of public radio stations, particularly in rural and economically distressed communities."

While I have noted that Trump has attempted to distance himself from Project 2025, this last policy suggestion is onewhe is comfortable with. In 2017, 2018, 2019 and 2020, Trump wrote in major cuts to the budget for CPB. The good news is that, in all four years, Congress — under both Republican and Democrat control — did not let him. We'll have to see what happens this time around.

Trump has also now tapped the author of Project 2025's chapter on the Federal Communications Commission, Brendan Carr, to be its chairman. Carr has previously said he would pursue attempts to penalize broadcast networks for perceived political bias. Trump himself had said he would like to take away the broadcast licenses for ABC and CBS because of their coverage of the campaign. While the networks themselves do not need the licenses, their local affiliates do.

In his Project 2025 chapter, Carr wrote that the FCC should be able to control Google, Apple, Meta and Microsoft — also known as "Big Tech." On X, he called these companies the "censorship cartel." Experts note his power as chairman does not give him absolute authority to make these decisions, but there might be ways to get around any blockades.

Kevin David Pointon / Openclipart

Indirect Hits

Another almost guaranteed Trump administration policy will be the gutting, or elimination, of the Department of Education. This, again, requires congressional approval.

Would this directly undercut the functioning of the free press in the U.S.? No. Indirectly? Absolutely. Education in this country has given students the tools to critically examine media and, at the most basic level, the ability to read. The current plan to gut the Department of Education involves stripping public schools and universities of the necessary (and already slim) funding they need to do their jobs as well as effectively nuking any support for special needs programs. This will arguably tank the already shockingly low literacy rate — just 79% of adults — in this country.

Another drawback to these cuts will be the loss of accessibility to education for low-income families via public schools and federal student loans, which could eliminate a demographic of potential journalists who can speak to the needs of and identify with low-income communities.

The Future

On a very depressing note, I'm actually not sure what can be done to fix — or begin to fix — this. When I speak of the Local News Crisis, I am optimistic. I have answers, or at least beginnings of them. Here, I am scared.

It is heartbreaking to have to think like this about something I love. Because I do love journalism.

For all of my complaints about individuals and certain publications, I still truly believe journalism is an awe-inspiring force I am proud to be a part of. It has the power to expose the truth and make great change. As Walter Cronkite once said: "Freedom of the press is not just important to democracy, it is democracy."

I am not ready to see democracy fall, but it might.

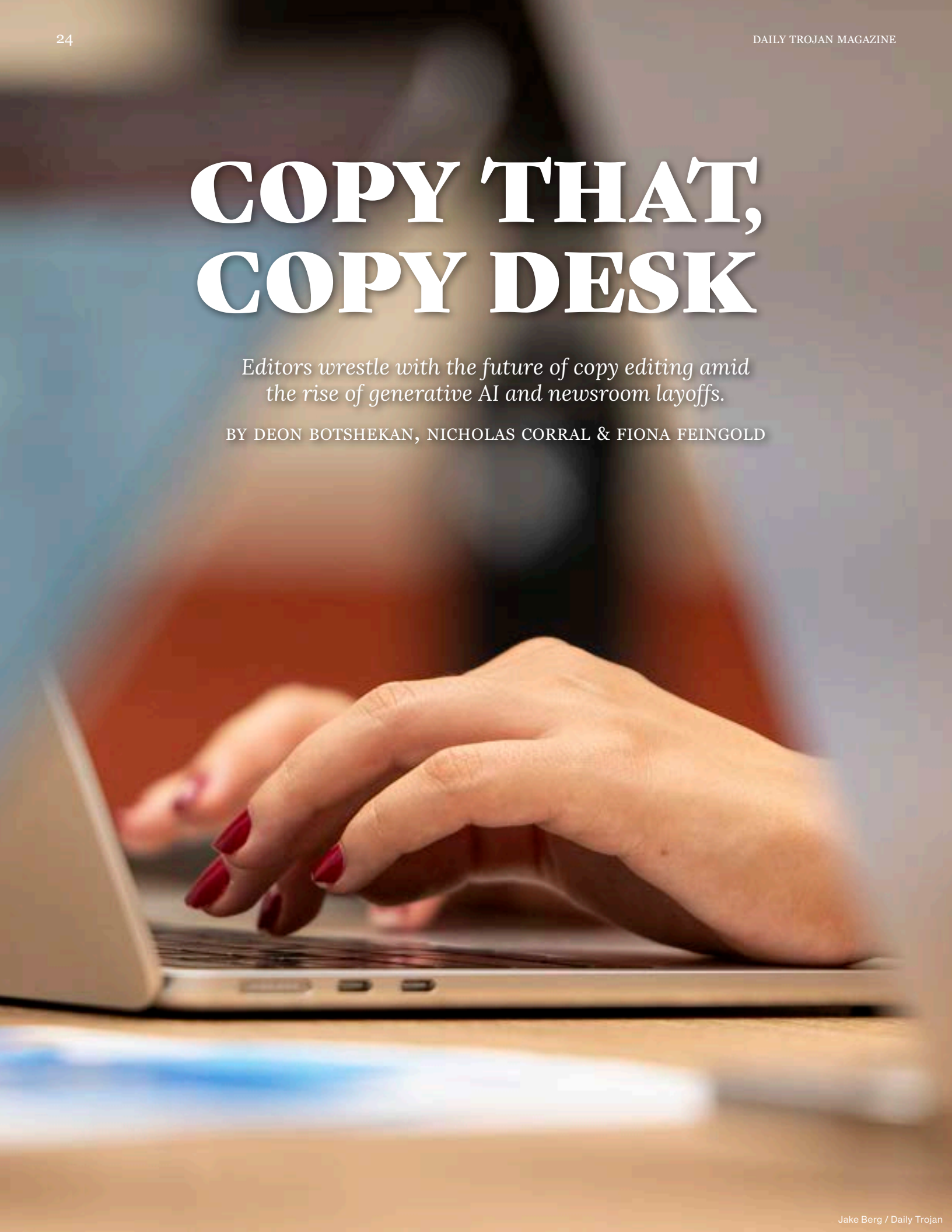
Jennifer Nehrer a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and the *Daily Trojan*'s Data editor. Nehrer is a junior majoring in journalism.

Jordan Renville / Daily Trojan file photo

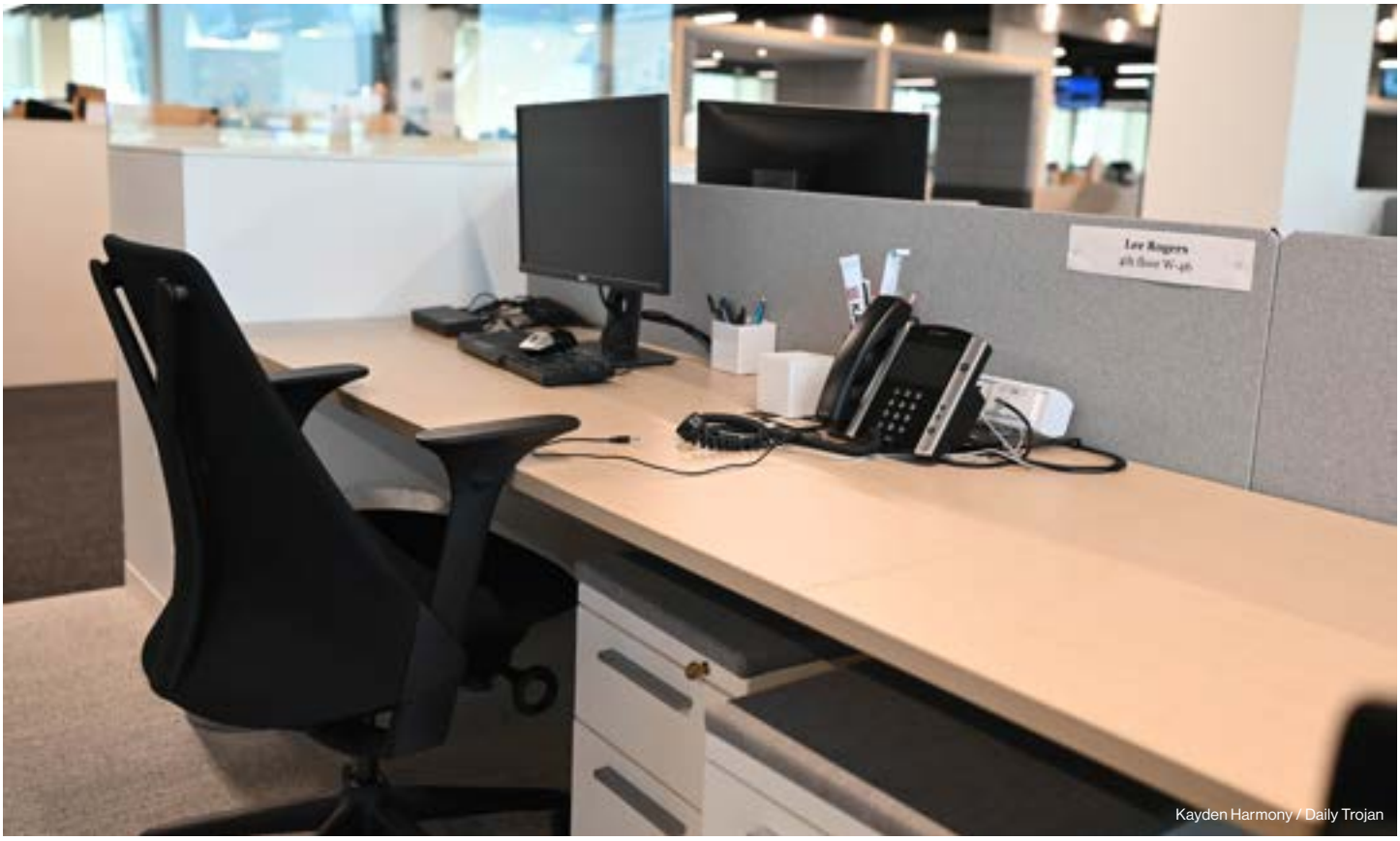
COPY THAT, COPY DESK

Editors wrestle with the future of copy editing amid the rise of generative AI and newsroom layoffs.

BY DEON BOTSHEKAN, NICHOLAS CORRAL & FIONA FEINGOLD



Jake Berg / Daily Trojan



Kayden Harmony / Daily Trojan

The year was 1997. ACES: The Society for Editing — formerly known as the American Copy Editors Society — was founded as a nonprofit organization dedicated to promoting excellence in copy editing.

Melissa McCoy, one of the founding members of the organization, was the foreign desk copy chief at the *Los Angeles Times*. She said the group came out of an American Society of News Editors summit that revealed the importance of copy editors to the newsroom.

"It just made all the difference because they went back to their individual newsrooms and really made more of an effort to show the work that copy editors did," said McCoy, now an adjunct professor at the Annenberg School for Communication and Journalism. "It can be very silent work … Can you imagine if a copy editor held their hand up every time they could fix something in a story? There would be hands raised all over newsrooms every day."

Flash forward 27 years, and the work of professional editors has become all too necessary. In a world with newsroom layoffs, rampant misinformation and artificial intelligence on the rise, the work of copy editors is more important than ever.

Often overlooked, copy editors are largely responsible for preventing both factual and grammatical errors from appearing in print. Editors fact-check information and ensure articles adhere to Associated Press and publication-specific style guidelines. At many publications, copy editors take a greater role in layout design by writing headlines and trimming articles as needed for space.

The *Daily Trojan* currently employs 30 copy staff — 25 copy editors, three deputy copy editors and two copy chiefs. Deputy copy editors are also on call for breaking news, often verifying information as it is being discovered. The copy team looks at every article three times before an issue hits newsstands; the chief copy editor on shift is usually the last person to read through an article before it is sent for print.

At the *L.A. Times* office in El Segundo, you would find much the same situation, down to the number of copy editors on staff. That's right — a national paper of record has nearly the same number of copy editors as a college paper.

Ruthanne Salido, an assistant managing editor at the *L.A. Times* overseeing its multiplatform editing desk, said there were over a hundred copy editors at the *L.A. Times* when she started in 1989.

Layoffs over the years — particularly in July 2023 and again this January — cut the size of the copy desk, and today the *L.A. Times* lists 34 multiplatform editors on its staff.

These cutbacks have not only hit copy desks. A Pew Research

Center analysis found employment at newspapers dropped by 51% from 2008 to 2019. Les Dunseith, a former copy editor and adjunct instructor, said newsrooms are likely to prioritize keeping content producers.

"When most people think of journalism, they think of reporters first," Dunseith said. "Anyone who was not doing a reporting job was more likely to have their job be among the first to be trimmed when cutbacks happen."

In 2017, *The New York Times* eliminated its copy desk of over 100 people as a separate part of the newsroom, folding the responsibilities into desks that edit content and style simultaneously. *The Texas Tribune* also eliminated its entire copy desk in 2023.

Elise De Los Santos, a former copy editor at the *Chicago Tribune* and a journalism professor at Northwestern University, said the typical position of copy editing has all but disappeared.

"The traditional role of being strictly on the print product and just copy editing stories for print … If that's all you're interested in doing, I don't think that job really exists anymore," De Los Santos said.

Annenberg itself no longer requires its journalism students to study copy editing. Around the turn of the century, required copy editing courses — along with other print-centric courses like page layout — became elective courses, and over the next decade, copy editing fell out of course offerings altogether.

Laura Castañeda, former associate director of the journalism school at Annenberg, said the decision was made to make room for other courses in multimedia and internet journalism as those aspects became more important in the early 2000s.

"There's all kinds of interesting classes out there. A lot of them are kind of technology-driven," Castañeda said. "Many students don't want to take copy editing. It's not, I guess, considered very sexy."

Dunseith said he last taught a course in copy editing in Spring 2017, and even then, it was offered as a seven-week special topic course. Only six students enrolled.

The growth of AI technology, and particularly its generative abilities, has raised concerns about the future of careers in journalism. These fears are particularly great in copy editing, which has already seen large cutbacks.

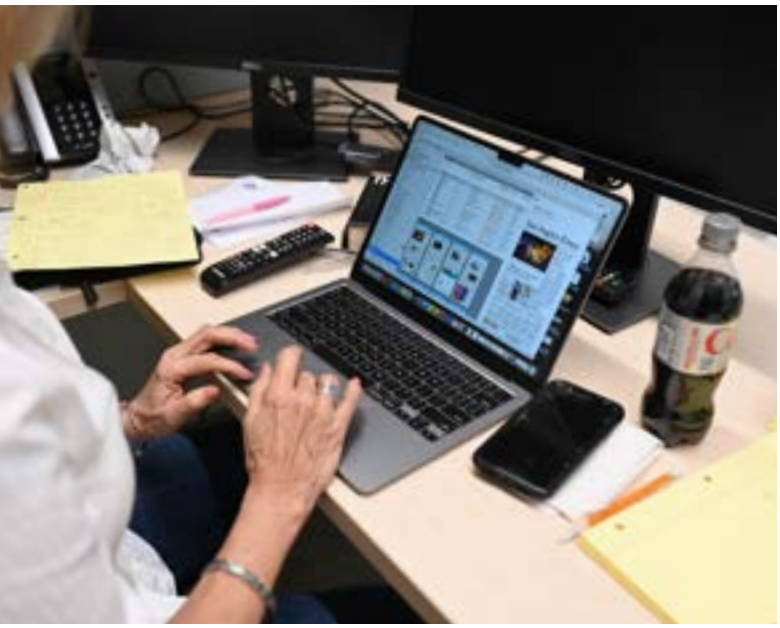
De Los Santos said the *Tribune*'s interest in AI primarily lay in its potential as a headline development tool. Using A/B testing, the publication experimented with showing readers different headlines and comparing their varying effectiveness. During De Los Santos' tenure, which ended in 2021, the *Tribune* avoided the use of generative AI.

"Newsrooms, especially at legacy corporations, like the *Tribune*, which is building off of a traditional newsroom structure, I think they remain pretty wary of [AI] but know that it's something that they have to know about and learn how to use in a way that's ethical," said De Los Santos.

Ananya Thyagarajan, a 2023-24 multiplatform editing fellow at the *L.A. Times*, said copy editors have a unique ability to interact with language that AI will never replicate.

"AI is never going to be able to have the kinds of thoughtful discussions around language that the copy editors have when we make changes to the style guide," Thyagarajan said. "AI is never going to suggest capitalizing the 'B' in Black.

Jake Berg / Daily Trojan



Photos: Kayden Harmony / Daily Trojan

Kayden Harmony / Daily Trojan

It's never going to think to be innovative or sensitive in language in a way that it hasn't been trained to."

De Los Santos reiterated the importance of being precise.

"There's a lot of assumptions that sometimes get baked into news because of just how fast paced it is. And things like that, being, just, aware about the questions we should ask and that how we describe people [matters] to them and to everyone reading about them — I think it's one really important role that copy editing … helps to play in journalism," De Los Santos said.

Meanwhile, Salido said part of the continued value of copy editors is the ability to work with reporters to make sure that content edits are correct.

"We're resilient or adaptable. When we don't get quite the answer we want from a reporter or line editor, we push and we push and we pursue and pose the question a different way," Salido said. "I don't know if an AI can do all that."

Alongside the increasing popularity of AI, the role of copy editors has changed following the growing threat of misinformation. Brian Cleveland, copy desk chief at *The Washington Post*, described copy editing as integral to combatting the dangers of misinformation.

"Building and maintaining that trust and relationship with people is the only way to break through all the noise. Copy editors have always been key to establishing that trust through the work that we do and the quality control that we provide," Cleveland said.

Cutbacks to copy desks, however, have often meant asking reporters and line editors — editors who work with the reporter to first shape the piece — to do more of their own copy editing.

"The defined role of what it means to be a reporter has expanded in the last decade or so," Dunseith said. "There's much more expectation that reporters know how to write their own headlines and know how to handle their own social media accounts and do their own podcasts and some of those kinds of things that would have been handed off to a copy editor."

Laura E. Davis, another professor at Annenberg, created Stylebot — a system that recognizes user text inputs to suggest relevant information about style. The system is targeted toward writers, reporters and line editors. She said she created the program to deal with the added time pressures she saw with reporting in the digital age.

"Stylebot is not about taking humans out of the process," Davis said. "It's acknowledging that more and more, because of the pace of publishing, because of the demands of multiplatform publishing, editing is a little bit more of everybody's job."

Davis said the greater impact of AI might be an increase in editing responsibilities — even if those roles aren't distributed to traditional copy desks.

"If AI is doing more writing, then people are doing more editing," Davis said. "These editing skills and really knowing your stuff is actually important because there's not a system out there right now that's going to automate it for you and get it exactly right every single time."

De Los Santos doesn't think aspiring student journalists should be scared of the growing importance of copy editing for everyone.

"The jobs that they are prob-

ably looking for … will require some level of copy editing because as that traditional role of just copy editor has changed and evolved, a lot of the responsibilities also shift onto the reporter or entry-level editor," De Los Santos said.

Salido also said she doesn't expect copy editing to disappear any time soon. She said that despite cuts to the copy desk, reporters want their work copy edited and the desk has been busier than ever.

"In theory, yes, we could do without the copy desk, but nobody really seems to want their material not copy edited," Salido said. "It's just the opposite … They want to know, 'Do we have the manpower to copy edit this?'"

As Thyagarajan nears the end of her fellowship at the *L.A. Times*, she said she plans to look for jobs outside of editing because of the cutbacks in the industry. In college, she majored in public health and environmental studies.

"The unfortunate truth is that copy editing is really not an industry that is doing well or even remotely okay right now," Thyagarajan said. "There is always going to be a need for journalism, and that need is going to be fulfilled somehow, but I don't think that there's any stability or any security in pursuing editing in a career format. So for me, what that means is staying flexible and looking for opportunities elsewhere."

In other ways, this change in responsibility has opened new doors for journalists striving to make themselves known in a notoriously difficult industry.

"I know it's scary, but I also say there's a lot of opportunity," De Los Santos said. "If you are someone who can dot their i's and cross their t's, that makes you stand out a little bit more among a big application pool."

Despite the changes to copy editing and industry-wide struggles, Salido remains committed to her work and the future of copy editing.

"Reporters, line editors and copy desk people — there are fewer of us all," she said. "But we're busier than ever because we're in a fight for our lives. We do want to survive as a newspaper, as a company. We're doing everything we can to try to survive and thrive. And we believe in journalism."

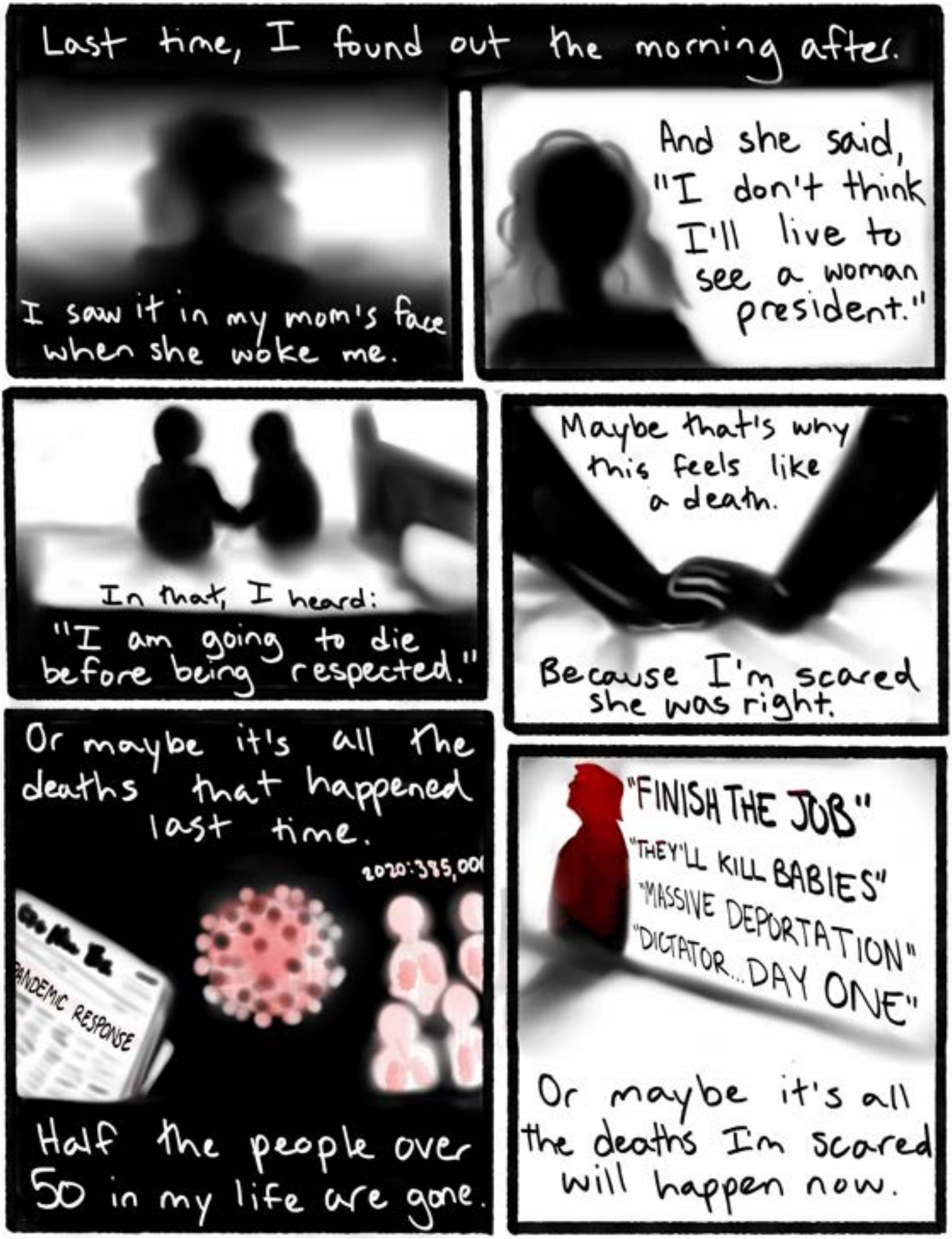
Disclaimer: Les Dunseith serves as faculty adviser at the *Daily Trojan*. He is not involved in content decisions.

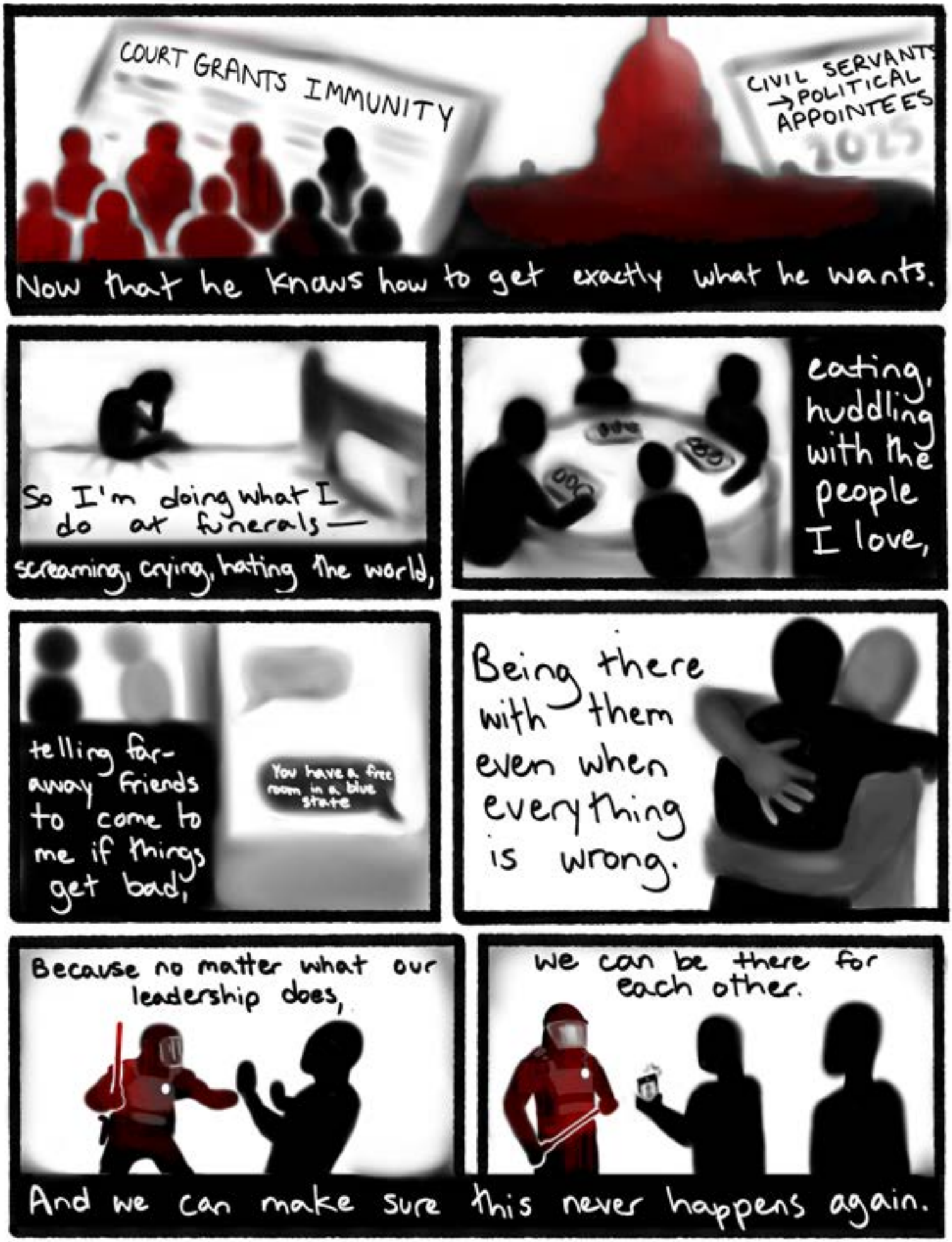
Deon Botshekan is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and chief copy editor at the *Daily Trojan*. Botshekan is a junior majoring in philosophy, politics and economics. Nicholas Corral is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and a News editor at the *Daily Trojan*. Corral is a sophomore majoring in journalism. Fiona Feingold is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and chief copy editor at the *Daily Trojan*. Feingold is a sophomore majoring in public relations and advertising.

Editor's Note: This story was updated on Wednesday, December 11 at 10:18 p.m. to change the phrase "fake news" to "misinformation" to portray an interviewee's statements more accurately.

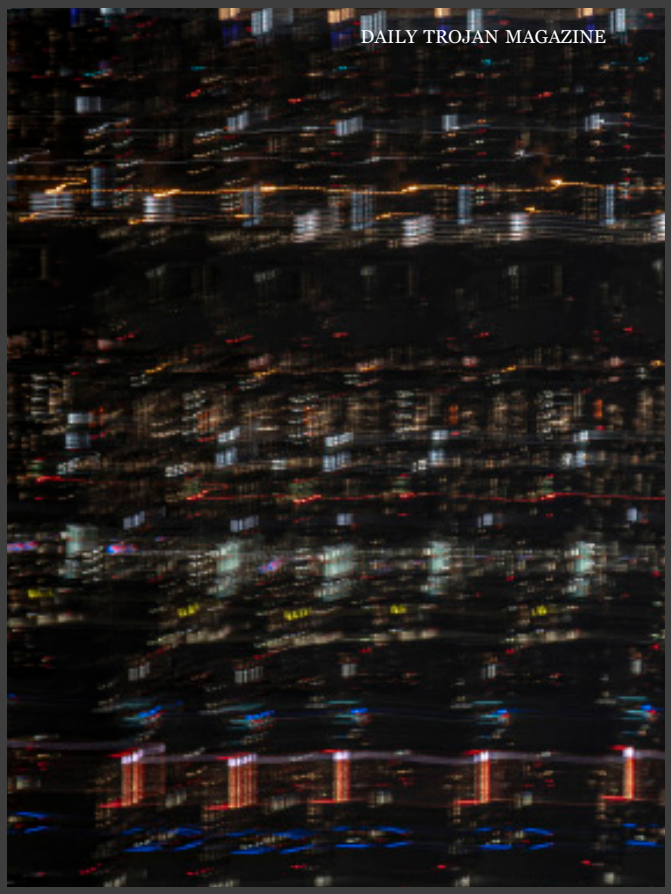
Correction: This article was changed on Thursday, December 12 at 2:26 p.m. to state that Melissa McCoy was a founding member of ACES, not a co-founder of the organization. The *Daily Trojan* regrets this error.

Jake Berg / Daily Trojan


Last time, I found out the morning after.
I saw it in my mom's face when she woke me.
And she said, "I don't think I'll live to see a woman president."
In that, I heard:
"I am going to die before being respected."
Maybe that's why this feels like a death.
Because I'm scared she was right.
Or maybe it's all the deaths that happened last time.
2020: 385,00
PANDEMIC RESPONSE
Half the people over 50 in my life are gone.
"FINISH THE JOB"
"THEY'LL KILL BABIES"
"MASSIVE DEPORTATION"
"DICTATOR... DAY ONE"
Or maybe it's all the deaths I'm scared will happen now.



COMIC: AMELIA NEILSON-SLABACH / DAILY TROJAN

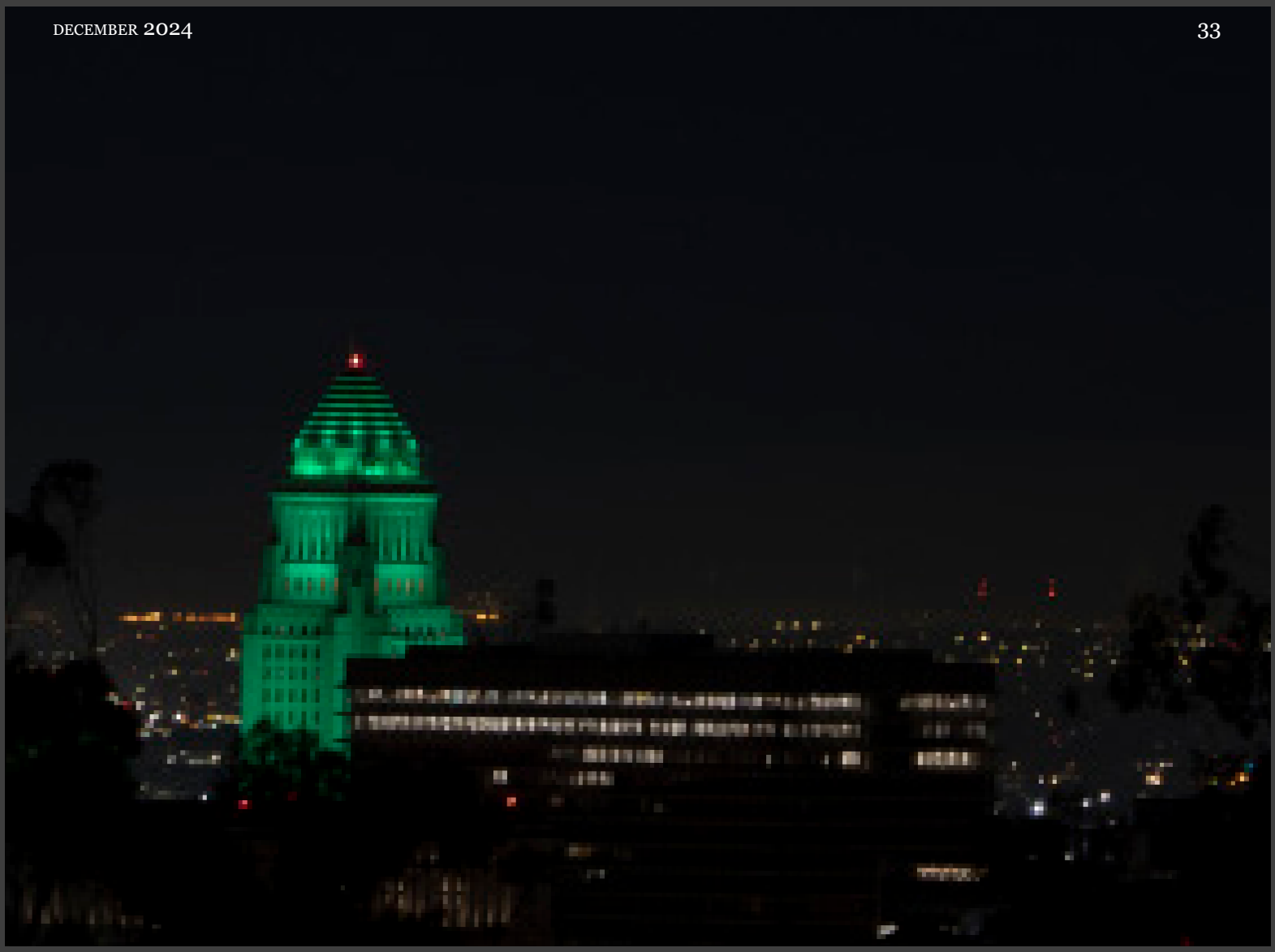


THE REAL WORLD

LA NIGHTS

BY SASHA RYU

With the winter solstice rapidly approaching, the sun seems to set earlier and earlier every day. After the last rays of sunlight disappear behind the horizon, the city takes on an entirely different form. At the beach, the moon reflects off the waves of the Pacific Ocean. Downtown, high-rises glow against the dark night sky. Music and laughter echo through late-night bars and clubs while the rest of the normally bustling city falls silent. After traveling from the shores of Santa Monica to the streets of downtown L.A., staff photographer **Jake Berg** has curated a collection of photos that capture the elusive beauty of a night in the city. Follow his journey through the city and take in the excitement and mystery of Los Angeles after dark.

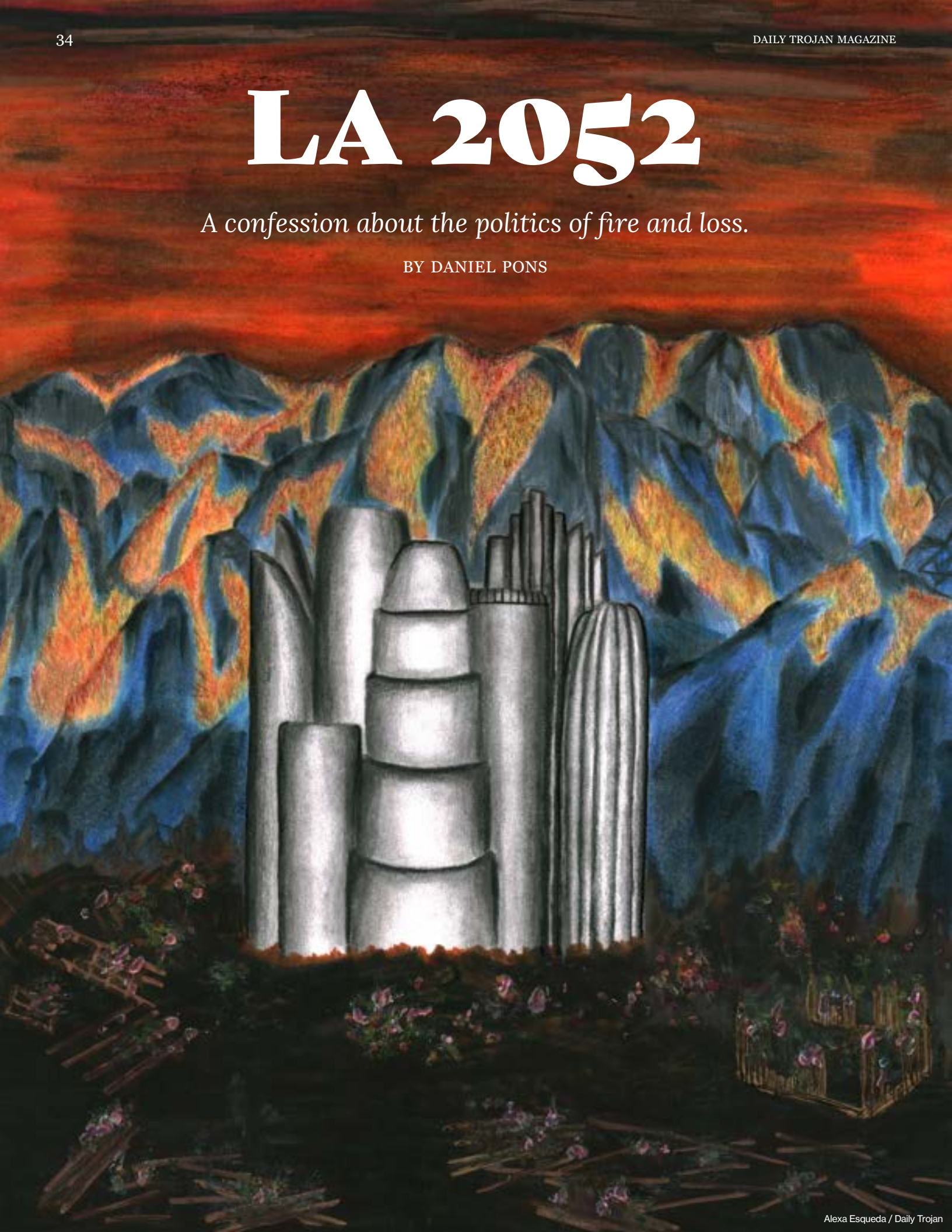


Photos: Jake Berg / Daily Trojan

LA 2052

A confession about the politics of fire and loss.

BY DANIEL PONS



Alexa Esqueda / Daily Trojan

Disclaimer: *This is a work of fiction. All characters and events are products of the author's imagination. Any resemblance to actual events or persons, living or dead, is almost entirely coincidental.*

My name is Jeremiah Cleveland. I am writing this letter from a dusty mountaintop in Santa Monica. Today is Dec. 27, 2052. Cracked, blackened earth now takes the place of Los Angeles, a memory carried by a quivering breeze. I fear I may be responsible for this tragedy. This is my confession.

I used to manage a cornfield in Iowa, a great swath of land bounded only by the horizon and an endless blue sky. It was my slice of paradise an hour out from Cedar Rapids, with a shed for my tools and a white shingled house shaded by a single oak tree. My daughter would go out and play by it as Josie made lunch, and I would be out sowing, reaping and selling. The sky would blaze with crimson, and I knew it would be time to wipe my brow and sit at the dining table for that night's dinner. At the crack of dawn, I would be there to tend to what the farm needed — braving God and His wilderness in the name of that which was orderly.

It was a charmed life, surely; a respite from the tribulations of the human condition. It was something I had under my control, something I could nurture and was a direct product of my own hand. But that was nearly 30 years ago, a time of comparably more mundane crises.

Once a year, on my daughter's birthday, we would go out to town to celebrate this most wonderful of milestones. We would go out for a great dinner and eat ice cream, something we missed back on the farm. We would then stroll to the midpoint of the 3rd Avenue bridge and watch the water run beneath us. It was on one of those birthdays that I received a letter from the United States Department of Agriculture when we arrived home.

Several major buyers had severed their connection to the farm. I was utterly baffled. I pulled open my laptop to see if South American corn had a bumper crop again this year. The news was far more foreboding: "Lab-grown corn cheaper than farmed for first time outside of California," read a headline in the Des Moines Register. Same in *The New York Times*.

I couldn't believe my eyes. I sat there paralyzed, my horror-stricken face illuminated by the glow of my laptop screen. I'm ashamed to admit that in my ensuing anger, I made certain that was the last that screen ever glowed. After I told Josie the news, she took me by the hand and into her arms. We quietly cried that night. Our lives were over as we knew it.

I don't recall when, in the following months, I received another letter signed by the USDA. I furrowed my brow and had half a mind to toss the damn thing. But I set it aside and watched the shadows cast by the corn, which had so generously and unwaveringly sustained my livelihood, trace an arc in front of my porch. For hours, it was just me, a beer and the letter on a bench surveying all that was lost.

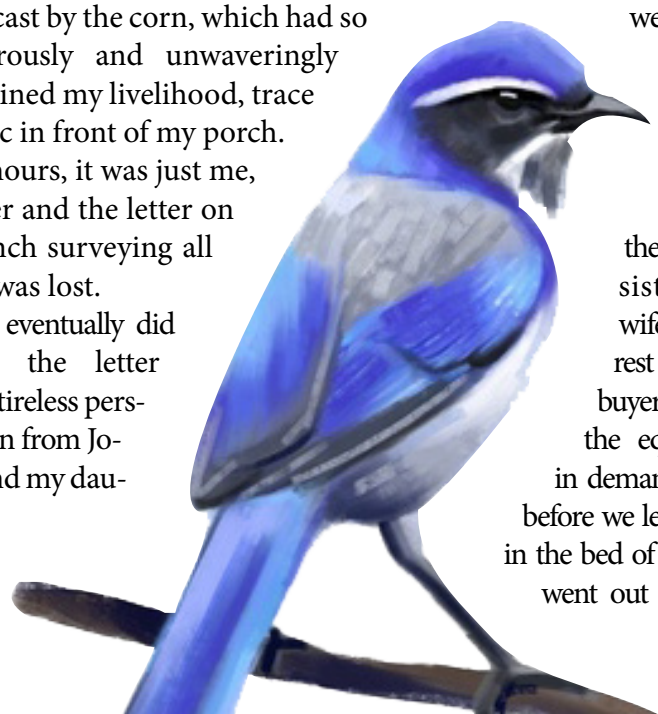
I eventually did open the letter after tireless persuasion from Josie and my daughter, Virginia, who was relentlessly curious about the world and could not stand the thought of an unopened letter. Eventually, I relented and tore open the envelope. Inside was a job offer from the USDA itself. I was shocked, to say the least. What could the government need from a simple farmer whose skills were rendered redundant by yuppies in lab coats?

Reading further, I saw the position was that of a "project manager" — presumably, they figured that managing a farm was transferable in that respect — but located in L.A.? I nearly tossed the paper when the salary gleaned from the bottom right of the sheet: $1 million in minimum annual income. My jaw dropped, and I pointed out the figure to my wife, whose jaw also dropped. Virginia came over to take a peek and shrieked, "One whole dollar!"

I wrote a letter back saying that the USDA would have to interview me in L.A. because that was where I was headed.

•••

The next day I received notice of a meeting place in the purported City of Angels. Our belongings were few, save for a trusted axe and a shotgun, some old furniture from generations passed, and the odd necessity insisted upon by my wife and daughter. The rest we sold, mostly to buyers overseas, where the equipment was still in demand. On the last day before we left, our lives tied up in the bed of the pickup truck, I went out to the fields that



Yiquan Feng / Daily Trojan

had nurtured my bloodline since it had parted ways with the British Isles.

I ran my hands through the stalks, tough to the touch but soft to the elements. My boots pressed into the saturated soil on my walk back home. I took it all in. Our modest home, the mighty oak. My heart swelled and deflated at the sight. I turned around, turned on the ignition and turned my life upside down, Virginia and Josie in the back.

We rushed by acres of untended land, tractors rusting in acres of wheat and corn. Further, we were bit by the dry air of the high Rockies and descended into the broiling pits of the netherworld once we reached the Mojave.

On the horizon was a thick black blanket — its edge dividing the sky. A line of cars poured in our direction from underneath it. We soon crossed the edge into the darkness. We strained our eyes to find the sun, which Virginia tentatively pointed out as a great red orb looming over us. Just under it, we could see the source of the smoke: A great ribbon of flame on the horizon, swatting at the minuscule helicopters that sought to tame it. Perhaps these were the famed fires of California.

Around us was nothing but a great plain of honey-colored grass — a curtain of smoky air obscured anything beyond it. Ash began accumulating on the base of the windscreen, which I occasionally wiped away. As we sped through this ocean of grass, I could have sworn that I occasionally spotted the melted forms of old tractors and harvesters sitting among this great tan expanse, scars of a bygone way of life.

We were at the base of what the map indicated to be the last set of mountains when we reached a blockade of fire-fighting vehicles preventing our passage. A man in a heavy green mask approached my truck. He told me that I had to turn around, that I would be driving into the mouth of hell itself if I were foolish enough to continue.

I told him I was there on some kind of government business, careful not to reveal my inexperience. To my astonishment, he waved me to a black helicopter, which I approached. The men instructed me and my family to leave the car as they slung masks over our faces.

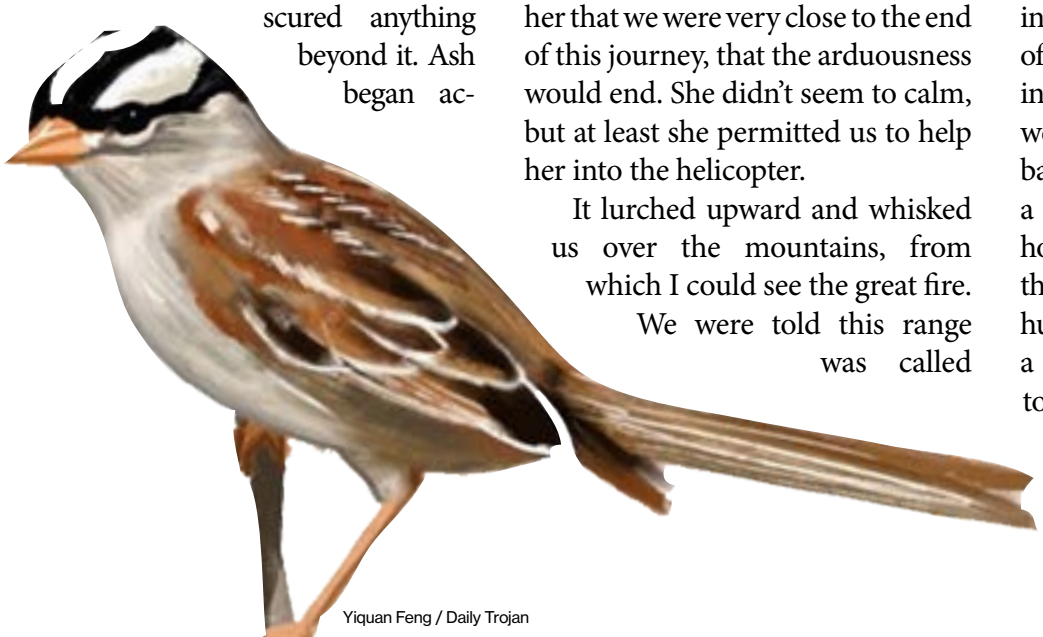
I asked about my vehicle and belongings — the men assured me they would be guarded safely — and we were ushered toward the large helicopter. I could barely hear it over the commotion and whirring blades, but as I stepped into the machine, I saw Josie cradling Virginia, who I could hear was sobbing. I rushed over, seeing she was shaking. I told her that we were very close to the end of this journey, that the arduousness would end. She didn't seem to calm, but at least she permitted us to help her into the helicopter.

It lurched upward and whisked us over the mountains, from which I could see the great fire. We were told this range was called San Gabriel and that it sent fire and misery into the city. I could see how circles ringed by red flame marked the point where brush was converted to dust. Other helicopters poured red and green powders onto the flames, which only stifled their march across the landscape. It was a beast to tame, I was told.

We soon cleared the range over into a blackened valley. The ground was nothing but ash and cinder, with the occasional puffs of smoke burped out. Straining my eyes, I could see lone trunks like blackened matchsticks and then rubble. The frame of a house, a lump of coal with headlights. Melted street signs. I was told it used to be called Pasadena; now it's called a tragedy. I looked over at Virginia, who had her face buried in my wife's dress, and then at Josie, who herself was squeezing her eyes shut.

The smoke began to clear, and descended on another valley — a great expanse of flatness, aside from the occasional mound or two. I entertained the idea that this place may be home yet. I noticed that everyone was looking in another direction. I turned my head to follow their gaze.

Great white towers were planted in the Earth like an immense stone hydra. They were like skyscrapers, but so closely knit and so uniform in texture they seemed carved out of a mountain; a monolithic David in the scale of Goliath. The towers were bordered by miles of exposed, barren terrain. The raw rock formed a crisp border with a sea of small homes extending to the ocean. It was the most profound expression of raw human power I had ever witnessed, a thwarting of the physics meant to constrain us. It embarrassed Versailles in its utter imposition of order and geometry on unrelenting nature.



Yiquan Feng / Daily Trojan

I could spot nary a tree. It was human creation, pure and unfettered. This was the City of Angels, sculpted by the hand of their godlike master.

We landed on a building overlooking this anthropic mountain in a place that was once an observatory, or a museum about observatories; the man escorting me was somewhat unclear on the matter himself. I was told Virginia and Josie were taken to our new place of residence to get settled. I was taken through long marble halls to meet my employer. Granted, I have omitted some of the mundanities of this process, but I was ultimately taken through heavy metal doors that led to a large desk with a small man behind it. He was bald and wore sunglasses indoors.

He informed me that the USDA sought to reintegrate many of the agricultural workers displaced and unemployed by the unprecedented shift in food production toward jobs responsible for managing these lands — "shepherds of opportunity," I recall him saying.

Based on my qualifications, the methods of acquisition for which I was never elucidated, I was best suited to be the chief architect of fire safety for the people of Los Angeles. Even at the time, I thought that it was a bit odd that such a large city would only now be employing such an evidently integral position given the severity of the issue at hand, but I took it in stride after I was lured by the benefits — free housing, insurance.

I was brought to my house with instructions that I would begin the job quite soon. It was a marvelous place, a two-story behemoth smothered in lavish plaster decor and red terracotta roofing. It was even flanked by palm trees to boot. The interior was sparse, dotted with the little furniture we had hauled halfway across the continent, but even then, I could see it becoming home. I met with Josie in the backyard. She stared wistfully to the horizon, blocked by a mountain that read, "Hollywood."

She told me that Virginia had fallen asleep upstairs, exhausted from the stress of the move. In turn, I relayed the day's meeting, to which she expressed the same perturbation I had; she asked if the decision was worthwhile.

"I could spot nary a tree. It was human creation, pure and unfettered. This was the City of Angels, sculpted by the hand of their godlike master."

"It was this or starvation," I mustered. It wasn't so bad. On some days, the sky even shone blue.

•••

The first morning of labor was rattling. Pumped full of apprehension, I whipped my pickup through the grid of the Angeleno suburbia. The streets were silent, with not a sound but the echo of my engine as I roared through. It felt reminiscent of the quiet of Iowa, except the quiet was more deafening and cold. There was no soft rustling of corn to backdrop my commute.

The suburbs then shifted to smoldering ruins, smoke wafting through the charred remains of neighborhoods and communities. The rubble was piled onto either side of the road, and I pressed onward. The blackness then became great planes of dried grass, a blanket of beige dropped onto the landscape, her curves and valleys naked to the eye. Bereft of the smoke on the other side of the mountains, I could take in the sheer immensity of the grass's coverage. The scenery had a strange beauty, almost surreal in its uniformity. It paralleled a wallpaper I recall seeing on my father's Windows desktop in childhood. How odd that the scenery was almost identical to that which I saw in the Central Valley, I had thought.

I then pulled into a cleft of the mountains, where my men were waiting for me. They, too, had come in their pickups — some with plates from Indiana, others Ohio, Arkansas and one Iowa. They, gruff as I but with yellow construction vests, had already gathered around a man dressed in black giving them instructions.They looked toward me, then the man.

"Your leader has arrived," he said, pointing a pen in my direction.

He gave me an orange vest and my orders: I was to clear these mountains of their fire-spreading brush Monday through Friday, eight to four. He explained that despite the great buffer between these wildlands and humanity, the embers from the brush can travel far by wind, and when they land on properties, they can ignite. The city of L.A. was aiming to relocate its millions of residents to the newly-built core, but it was our job to eliminate the threat.

"And the grass?" I had asked, wondering if this plant was, too, a menace.

He said it kept the hills from eroding since bare slopes lead to landslides. His nonchalance regarding the matter was enough for me. It was a moment of silence I would come to regret.

The man roared away in his unmarked vehicle, and I was left with my fellows. After a brief silence, I was informed that we were given four bulldozers and two excavators to share between us, a group of nine. They were a silent bunch, but I figured I could assign seven to vehicles and stay with two to supervise. The men nodded and clambered into their vehicles.

After some minor difficulties, the machines began their crawls up the mountainside, scraping away the green and red of nature's kindling. Every so often, a burst of birds would fly out, squawking in fright and confusion.

One of the two men, Derek, who had remained tight-lipped to this point, remarked that the birds scattering took him back to days of duck hunting with his father. The other, Chris, agreed, but said that for him it was pheasants. I myself had never gone hunting, but in the spirit of conversation, I chimed in that I had brought my shotgun on the trip. Both remarked they had done the same. And then, suddenly, we arrived at the same conclusion.

"You know," Derek drawled, "we have a chance to do some good ol' huntin', like back on the farm."

We agreed, and I felt it could be an opportunity for bonding. In the same way, we were alone together.

At that moment, an excavator tipped over and slid down the hill. It screeched and screamed as metal scraped against rock, and all activity ceased as we watched it make its way to the road. I shot toward the machine in the hopes that the man inside was still breathing. To my surprise, he jumped out, grabbed my shoulders and began sobbing.

"I'm so sorry boss," he cried. "Please, I need this job."

He continued about his family and his farm. I lifted his chin and told him that as his boss I would let him stay and that it was an understandable accident. I did ask him, though, how he could tip the thing if he — like me — had been chosen specifically for this position? He sniffled, sighed and explained that he was told the same thing, but he had only ever operated farm equipment on flat ground. I later learned that this man was called John.

"His nonchalance regarding the matter was enough for me. It was a moment of silence I would come to regret."

By this point, all seven other men had gathered around me. I asked them in earnest if any of them had operated this equipment before, and all shook their heads. I offered to call the supervisor and ask for an explanation, but they all shouted in protest with the same plea: They needed this job. I looked at the men, shaken, lost. I saw myself in them. I advised that they clear low to moderate gradients and save the higher ones when they have had greater experience. The men smiled tearfully, and by 4 p.m., we had amassed our own mountain of cleared brush. We said our goodbyes and dispersed to our residences.

•••

The next morning, we gathered again and found the pile of vegetation we had left had been cleared, and we presumed it was the doing of the men in black. After a quick meeting, we began to tear away at the green covering the hillside. There was a hard line separating yesterday's job from today's and tomorrow's. On one side, dark green vegetation supported by red and brown twisting bark; on the other, raw, yellow decomposed granite.

Today, John and a man named Michael were by my side to supervise. We leaned on our trucks, watching bursts of birds flutter out of the brush as it crunched under our machines. John was quiet but visibly less nervous. Before I could open my mouth to ask how he was, a crack rang through the mountains, and an explosion of blue feathers rained down on a bulldozer.

I whipped around and saw Michael in the bed of his pickup, cocking his rifle with a great grin on his face. "Just like back home," he smiled. I could do nothing but express my admiring astonishment.

"I'll be damned."

The bulldozer, now dotted in blue, stopped, and a man came running out. He frantically inquired about the commotion, and when I told him the cause, he beamed and asked if he could join. My immediate instinct was to welcome the opportunity, but as we were still on the job, I felt it was best to devise an alternative solution. I asked John his thoughts.

He suggested we rotate who is on break every two hours, covering all eight men. I patted him on the back, congratulated him for a great idea and eventually relayed this system to the rest of the group. They cheered, and every two hours a new pair would shoot at the birds fleeing from our machines. I was asked to participate, but I felt it was important to maintain a professional distance from my men; I was their boss, after all.

As the days passed and we shaved the mountainside, the game began to evolve. Derek, the most competitive member of the group, suggested that they keep score, and brought with him a board with our names written on it. His point system was straightforward: black and brown birds were one point, blue were three, yellow were five and birds of prey were worth 10. Once we got into the valleys where the oaks grew, we added woodpeckers and ducks to our system, both worth six points.

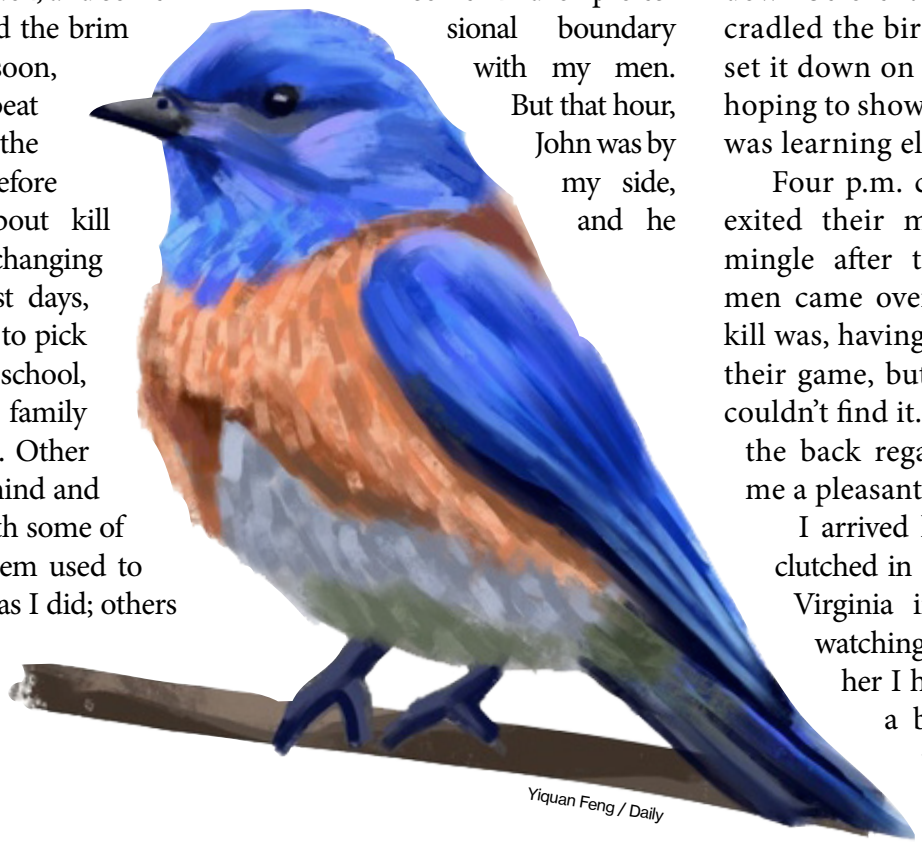
It soon became ritual for the men to collect their kill between shifts and load it onto Derek's truck, and some days, it nearly reached the brim of the bed. Very soon, as the 4 p.m. sun beat down on our necks, the men began to dally before leaving, bragging about kill counts and then exchanging personal stories. Most days, I bade them goodbye to pick up my daughter from school, spent time with the family and on my lonesome. Other days, I would stay behind and exchange histories with some of my men. Many of them used to live and breathe corn as I did; others harvested soybeans, and others still wrangled cattle. All replaced by the ever-thirsting vacuum of progress.

They told me how they received the news in all sorts of manners: through mail, a sign outside their property, a trusted friend. But we were all offered the job in the same circumstances: after a couple of months of hopeless destitution.

We were, of course, living far more lavishly and comfortably than what was afforded by the lifestyle of our previous occupation, but many of us missed the simplicity. Without much incentive to go back, though, we remained complacent in our overpaid maintenance jobs.

For months, we would perform our ritual of labor: clearing, shooting, chatting and leaving. We had grown tight as a group, weaving our way through the peaks and valleys of the San Gabriel Mountains as we ever more deftly shaved them of their bush.

Eventually, and in retrospect, inevitably, I was asked to join their shooting game. I expressed some hesitation for my want to maintain some kind of professional boundary with my men. But that hour, John was by my side, and he grabbed his shotgun, held it out and simply asked, "Please." By this point, I had grown a particular fondness for the man of few words, so I took it and waited for the next flock of escapees.



Yiquan Feng / Daily

A group of three blue-backed, white-breasted birds escaped from a large, red-berried shrub Michael was approaching with his bulldozer. I took aim, shot at them and plucked one from the group. It dove into another bush. John and the other man, Winston, cheered. Satisfied, John took back his shotgun when I handed it back.

When the time came for them to switch places, I snooped the area where it had fallen and picked it up. I had hit it straight in the chest, and red soaked its white breast. I examined the bird closer. Its blue back shimmered in the sunlight; it seemed to glow. I turned it over in my hand. It had a blue necklace running around its neck and white eyebrows. The bird was beautiful. I felt grief creeping up my throat, but I swallowed it down before it reached my eyes. I cradled the bird in my palms and set it down on my passenger seat, hoping to show it to Virginia, who was learning elementary biology.

Four p.m. came, and the men exited their machines, ready to mingle after the day's end. My men came over to ask where my kill was, having heard I partook in their game, but I remarked that I couldn't find it. They patted me on the back regardless and wished me a pleasant afternoon.

I arrived home with the bird clutched in my hand and found Virginia in the living room watching the television. I told her I had a question about a bird, and when she turned around to see

one dead in my hands, she jumped. I reassured her it was dead, and she examined it, her hands behind her back. She then ran over to her backpack, extracted a thin booklet and opened it to a bookmarked page.

"That's a scrub jay," she said with the authority of any child who had just learned something new in school. She turned around the booklet so that I could read it and said, "See?"

And so it was a scrub jay. "Good job," I told her, and I tussled her hair. "May I have a look?"

"Okay!" she replied sweetly and gave me the book. Such a heartwarming girl. I carried the bird and book to the yard and read the supplementary facts under a bloody sky.

"The scrub jay is one of several jays native to California. It can be distinguished by its blue back, white belly, blue 'necklace' and gray upper back." I turned around the bird and saw the patch of gray feathers between the wings. "Scrub jays often forage in family groups of two or three. This bird is known to spread and plant tree seeds as it stores them for the winter. These plants are flammable, so to keep your family and neighbor safe, you should eliminate them on sight."

I dropped the booklet. Is this what they were telling my kid? I was about to storm into the living room to understand what in tarnation they were saying to my Virginia, but I looked at the sky, its deep red, the blanket of soot. I looked at the bird. It's just fulfilling its duties to its family, but that endangers mine. I took the booklet, set it down on a countertop and laid the jay in some bare earth. I looked to the sky, then down at the bird.

"I'm sorry about the loss of your job," I whispered. I then covered it in soil and sat beside it, looking upward.

I felt the guilt creep back up my throat. But this time, I let it reach my eyes. Tears fell on the mound covering the jay. I cried for him and his family.

•••

A year had passed since I first took the job. The winter rains had brought about several landslides of the rock we denuded, impeding progress for about a week at a time, but my men had grown so adept with the machines that clearing all types of terrain was a facile task. Boulders, oaks, cougars, they quaked all the same at the weight of our might. The line dividing rock and green pushed further north, and the commute to our starting location grew ever longer.

It also appeared that these rains washed the sky clean. When blue was once a rarity, it became everyday. A true rebirth of nature.

In spring, I was surprised by fields of green pasture running from the houses up through the mountains, blanketing the scars we wreaked over the peaks. There was one occasion when, through the clear March air, we caught a glimpse of another team tearing through the brush across a valley. We unspokenly chose to race the other team to the bottom, and they did the same; we won by two hours. That afternoon, we went to a bar to celebrate.

When I came home, Josie rushed me into the kitchen. I was still kicking off my muddied boots when she pointed at an article she had pulled open on her laptop screen.

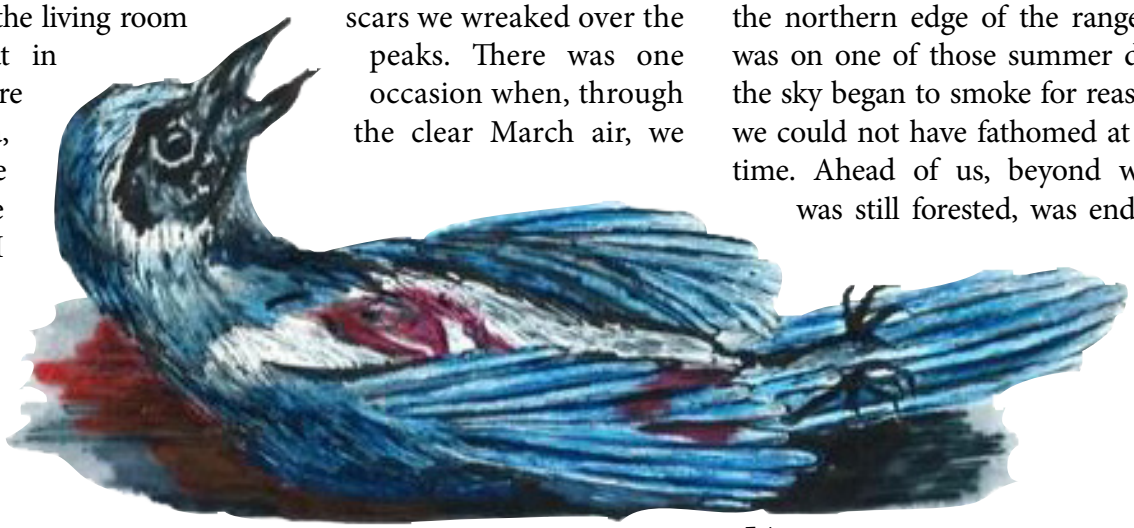
"Fires Begin to Ravage Central Valley Early," the headline read. I told her that she needn't worry about it affecting us — those fires did not have enough fuel to cross the mountains which we had cleared of vegetation; rock does not ignite. In spite of the explanation, she still looked perturbed.

"Virginia has been telling me about what she's learning," Josie said nervously, running her hand through her hair. "I just get the feeling that we may not be doing enough."

"Ridiculous," I scoffed, "The fires won't reach the city because we cleared the brush. There's no need to focus on what I'm doing. How about you focus on making dinner?"

•••

Summer came, green faded to tan and we pushed ever further toward the northern edge of the range. It was on one of those summer days the sky began to smoke for reasons we could not have fathomed at the time. Ahead of us, beyond what was still forested, was endless



Alexa Esqueda / Daily Trojan

azure. Behind us, beyond the hills of honey, was a wall of blackness meeting the clouds. I received a call. They were evacuating the city.

We all jumped into our cars, motivated by one terrifying thought. We snaked through the honeyed hills in our pickups, roaring as fast as the turns would let us. The air grew thicker as the smoke built, and once we descended the mountain, we could see plumes of ash erupting from the fields ahead.

In our foolhardy bravery, we forged ahead. Our progress was eventually impeded by a blast of heat so intense it evoked the sensation that my skin was melting. We all stopped, except for one pickup — John. I stared, dumbfounded, as he raced into the smoke.

Helicopters soon descended over the inferno, pouring water and chemicals in an effort to abade its fury. Not until the sun was descending over the horizon had the flames quelled.

I pulled through the carnage, the air quivering around us. Black ash and embers floated on its currents. I then reached the edge of what had been a neighborhood, now smoky ruins. A pickup truck lay melted by the side of the road, with a blackened figure at the wheel. I tried not to imagine the implications.

Further down, my house was rendered a platform for kindling. I pulled over on the street, unable to access the driveway for it was covered with my kitchen. I waded through the rubble, flinging it aside in the hopes of finding any preservation of my past life. All ash and charcoal.

I flipped over a blackened plank, and a scrub jay burst from the wreckage, light smoke trailing behind it. It looked back, squawked and flew out of sight. I turned my gaze back to where it had been. A neat pile of dirt, pristine and circular, sat in the wreckage. Could this be? I dusted it off. No, it was an acorn. I pinched the acorn between my fingers and lifted it to my eyeline for examination. I hesitated — and put it back in the ground.

After more searching through the rubble I found a cracked picture frame containing a photograph of me, Josie and Virginia in front of the old oak by our home in Iowa. That was our home. I clutched the photo to my chest and sniffled, tucking it into my jacket.

"I knew my wife and daughter had been evacuated. What I didn't know at the time was that I would never have the chance to see them again."

Josie called me and quelled the worst of my fears — I knew my wife and daughter had been evacuated. What I didn't know at the time was that I would never have the chance to see them again.

•••

When Josie informed me that she was leaving the country with Virginia, I was dumbfounded. Our conversation lasted for hours — until she had to board the plane. Only months later did I understand the necessity of her choices, but my judgment was clouded by pride and hurt in the moment and the months after.

I was relocated to a new house on the outer edge of the clearing that buffered the central city. For many days I would sit on my porch and gaze at it, our supposed solution. I had never dared enter it, the cracks between those divine white columns. Work no longer interested me, and it did not seem that it interested anyone to incentivize my return. So I sat, and I drank.

Sometimes Josie would call me. I would always let it ring. No wife should leave her husband, not if it becomes hell on Earth. My conscience would of course object to this terribly selfish line of reasoning, but I found that enough alcohol can drown that dissent. Over months the calls eventually began to subside in frequency.

One intoxicated afternoon, my vision beginning to blur and my head beginning to droop, I saw a waft of smoke from behind the city. A blemish on the yellow of the mountains was beginning to burn. A helicopter quickly flew over the flame and doused it, but the scene etched itself into a cavity in my brain. It remained there for weeks, immune to the onslaught of midday alcohol consumed to cure the morning's hangover.

It was one of these migraine-inflicted mornings that I eschewed inebriation to answer an unspoken question that was beginning to develop. I hopped into my pickup, caked in dust, and set off for the mountains once more.

The edge of rock and brush was where we had left it. I rifled through my glove compartment and pulled

out a flare. After exiting my vehicle, I removed the cap and struck it. Red flame shot forth. I spotted a shrub and approached it, the flare sparking. The leaves were large and glossy, supported by dark brown branches. I held the flare to the leaves. Nothing. I pressed it to the bark. Some smoke began to emerge from the wound, but pulling the flare away revealed a weak flame burning into the bark. I was able to snuff it out in seconds.

I then turned my attention to a patch of tan grass by the roadside. I took the flare to it, and it burst into flames. I recall my yelp reverberating through the valley, and I frantically attempted to stomp it out. The kindling potential for the grass was striking. I then turned back and gazed upon the great beige blanket that had replaced the deep green shrubbery we had so fervently razed. My knees wobbled and slumped onto the ground, mouth agape.

I do not know for how long I kneeled there, at the edge of the San Gabriel Mountains, but I remember the sky was bleeding when I returned home. Scarlet light was cast onto the hills, illuminating the grass in a fiery glow. All I could do was look around and take in the great red emptiness. I arrived home as the last fingertips of the sunset pierced the sky.

•••

The findings played through my thoughts without pause. I could not fathom how I stumbled this far in complete blindness to the realities that governed the basic nature of our world. My heart was wrung by the uncertainty I felt.

I sat in my living room and stared absent-mindedly at a wall as I sipped a beer, until my eyes focused and realized that I was staring at the photo I collected from the wreckage of our old house. I lifted myself from my seat and ambled toward it.

"That life is up in flames," I thought sardonically. In that moment, I felt a mental jolt, like the illumination of some disparate part of my brain that had been ignored until then. I staggered back, and my beer shattered on the floor.

I rushed to my car to drive to the outskirts of town. It skidded to a halt where homes met rubble. Just as I had suspected. Tufts of grass were peeking from between fallen beams. I looked out to the once-barren mountains we cleared of green. Yellow. I then thought back to the first day I arrived here, how we passed through fields with charred tractors and harvesters. How they were engulfed in a sea of dry grass. I stood there, amazed with my realization. I stepped into my pickup and began driving.

The old observatory pulled into view. I stepped in, unquestioned, and marched into the office of the bald man in black.I burst into the room, and he merely raised an eyebrow in acknowledgement of my presence.

With exasperated fury, I began, "Sir, do you know that removing farmers from their land leaves it barren and open for this highly flammable grass to move in and spread? And that once it burns down something, it moves in to replace it?" I said. "That clearing the damn forest is only making room for more grass? That it's not the shrubs burning down half the city every year?"

The man stared blankly at me. "Who are you?" he said. "If you have a formal complaint, you may send it in through—"

"I work for you!" I shouted.

That appeared to jog his memory. He collected himself, and replied that clearing was policy and that all plants burned, though some remain impossible to eliminate completely.

I told him of my experiment with the shrub. "I've never heard of such a thing," he replied.

"And you made sure to hire vulnerable people who have also

Yiquan Feng / Daily Trojan

never heard of such a thing?" I spat. "Who would crawl on their hands and knees through fire to protect their families, and would take your offer without questioning if what they were doing was remotely effective? That you would only hire 'yes men' who will grovel to your every whim?"

He pointed to the door. and said, "Get out."

In my rage, all I could do was turn around and leave — though not before hurling a chair at his shiny bald head. I sprinted to my car, started the ignition and drove home. I knew the act would have my home searched and confiscated, so I grabbed the picture frame and drove west along the ocean and turned into the mountainside. Looking over the city, I could see another fire begin to erupt.

...

My phone buzzed in my pocket. I picked it up. It was Josie. My conscience spoke up, and I finally answered.

Josie explained that the evacuations were swift and brutal; she and Virginia were whisked to the tower city with barely enough time to grab necessities, nevermind inform me. The evacuation was so immense that the city could not handle the influx of people, so planes were filled with families to carry them to safety; in Josie and Virginia's cases, they were flown to La Plata, Argentina.

Josie then told of the lack of fires in Argentina, how they still farmed not for profit but as a way of life, and how millions of people have fled there seeking the same as her. She initially had the intention of returning to L.A., but found a life working in a bakery, Virginia was going to a bilingual school, and how she wanted me to come. She thought I could farm once again. Every phone call since was a plea for my visiting, a chance to tell me that she still loved me.

My heart dropped. What a bastard I was. The conversation continued for what seemed like hours. We laughed, cried, exchanged histories and cried yet more. Virginia was happy in La Plata; everyone seemed quite welcoming of her and Josie. I then told her of what I had discovered.

"We are our own undoing. Our flaws are too great to be effective stewards of the Earth."

There was silence from the phone. After a tense, silent minute passed. She then mustered, "Why did they let this happen?"

...

The following is the bitter truth about the previous events and our future as a society. This much I have pieced together.

We are our own undoing. Our flaws are too great to be effective stewards of the Earth. Regardless, this position was self-appointed and thrust upon us, and is ours to bear. As a collective, we exist in a paradox of endless curiosity and a limitless defiance of evidence that curiosity brings us. The fact of our nature is thus: We are very clever apes but very stupid gods.

For decades we have understood and recorded how our cities disrupt the lands around them. That our trade brings in species that take advantage of the space and burn down everything in their wake to make room for themselves. Of course, it's only okay when we do it.

And yet, in spite of the evidence, we feel the need to meddle with these systems for our own agendas. To clear land for supposed fire prevention, to impregnate wilderness with neighborhoods and strip malls. With us, the foreign species' invasion will follow, seeding itself in the nooks and crannies of habitat and burning it. There is yellow on the hills of L.A., by the highways, in the parks, in backyards — it's invasive, and it's flammable. The city will always be at perpetual risk of flame as long as its hills remain yellow.

When we abandon spaces once relished by the creatures of nature, nature is not the one who comes back. It is parasitic grass. Land cleared for development, empty farmland, roadsides — all fill with this invasive kindling.

It spreads by going to seed and drying up before its native competition; in that way, it burns them out before they have the chance to replenish the soil with the next generation. These plants ensure their survival by eliminating all competition. In a way, their ecology reflects our own human nature.

I don't think the men responsible for clearing native habitat by development understand the

counterintuition of their actions. I don't think the men in politics understand either. They, like us, make decisions based on their biases and the knowledge they have twisted to fit their worldviews. They, too, are incompetent stewards. They will compound their incompetence by surrounding themselves with those who blindly agree or are too terrified to say "no," because they — we — don't like to feel wrong.

The main difference between us and them is that they never face the consequences of their poor decisions. An incompetent politician may leave office, but he will die before the wrath of their actions is felt by the electorate.

Our position as individuals is bleak, but only because we overcomplicate problems in worship of our purported complexity. The world is not as complicated a place as we imagine it to be. It operates in ways we can never understand, not for the limits of our mental hardware but the limits of the paradigms we use to interpolate it. The way I see it, life's great operating principle is thus: equilibrium and harmony.

Nature seeks to create a balance in its system, such that all life and death are meant for something. A deermouse is born from a mother who ate worms in a rotting log. Human nature used to be a component of the system. He who did not fit into the tribe was kicked out and eaten by lions. Now, we are so vast that tribes are warring clans and we all strive to feed one another to the lions. The same goes for our relationship with nature.

A river floods, we put it in a concrete ditch. A coyote enters a neighborhood that five years ago was acres of shrubland, we shoot it. A patch of land catches on fire, and we raze it to the ground. It, of course, never occurred to us to not build directly by the river, to leave space for the coyote or not sprawl into the foothills. Those decisions, though, have already been made.

All we can do now is choose not to cut down the bush and plant it some friends.

•••

The events that transpired can serve as a warning for those who have not yet fallen into that same spiral. I hope to tell my story so that someday, someone may listen. So that others do not make the same mistake I did, that we did. I have relayed my story in a series of letters, to be pieced together and distributed by you. I will come to you, my darling Josie. This is my last letter, for now.

Daniel Pons is a staff writer for the Daily Trojan Magazine and the *Daily Trojan*'s Spanish Supplement editor. Pons is a junior majoring in geodesign.

CreativeNia / DeviantArt

Jake Berg / Daily Trojan

Small business, big impact

How James and Cindy Choi are using their boba shop to build community at USC.

BY ABBY WEILAND

The first time I stepped into USC Village, I was greeted by the sight of a long line stretching out of a storefront, bustling with lively college students. Curious about the buzz, I asked what all the excitement was about. It turned out that the crowd was drawn by the recent opening of Yoboseyo Superette, a new boba shop on campus.

Yoboseyo Superette opened at USC Village just in time for the start of the school year. The new boba shop — which has quickly become a student favorite in the six months since it arrived at the University — blends boba drinks, retail items and hip ambiance to create a "specialty market bodega."

"When I first walked into Yoboseyo, I loved the ambiance. It was so fun, and I also was so excited when I saw they sold Swedish candy," said Sasha Khadka, a freshman majoring in business administration.

James and Cindy Choi own and operate the store, alongside Cafe Dulce — a popular chain with three locations in Los Angeles, including one at USC Village.

Before the couple met, James and Cindy were both involved in the food and hospitality industry. After getting his bachelor's degree in accounting as well as business administration at USC, James owned a Swiss chocolate boutique called Teuscher in Palo Alto, and Cindy was a marketing manager for the Chaya Restaurant Group in San Francisco. After meeting through a mutual friend, the couple dated for five years then moved from the Bay Area to L.A., where they got married and went into business together.

K Cox / Daily Trojan

After a few years of running Cafe Dulce and the Yoboseyo Superette located in Little Tokyo, the couple reached out to USC's in-house real estate department to ask about the possibility of opening a shop at USC Village. When they heard there was an available space in the shopping center, it felt like a sign that it was the perfect opportunity for the Chois to make their dreams a reality.

The couple decided to open a second Yoboseyo Superette this year. The first, which opened in 2022, is a two-story complex located in Little Tokyo. The Little Tokyo location started as a coffee bar and evolved into a coffee and matcha shop. While the Yoboseyo Superette in Little Tokyo doesn't sell boba, the Yoboseyo Superette at USC Village specializes in boba.

All of the drinks from Yoboseyo come in cups with the store's logo — a smiling girl with pigtails — which the couple designed based on their now six-year-old daughter, Autumn. The name is inspired by the season when the couple officially started dating and also holds special meaning as it marks the season of Autumn's birth.

The two locations share one key similarity: both have a retail section that sells products from small businesses.

Starting out as small business owners themselves, the Chois understand the struggle of building a business. When they were planning to open Yoboseyo Superette, they wanted to find a way to spotlight and help other small business owners.

In an interview with the *Daily Trojan*, Cindy said she wants to foster a sense of community by supporting a diverse array of small businesses.

"It's kind of become like a neighborhood space for the different organizations," Cindy said.

At first, they considered sharing the space with another company, but they

Teo Gonzales/ Daily Trojan

eventually realized that they would rather bring in and sell products from multiple small businesses.

Yoboseyo Superette sells products from businesses ranging from chili oil to cookbooks to plants. The hope is that while customers are waiting for their drinks, they can shop around and support local businesses.

When the Chois opened the first Yoboseyo Superette, many small businesses were still recovering from the coronavirus pandemic. Cindy and James, hoping to help, began reaching out to small businesses to see if they wanted to sell their products in their store.

One of Yoboseyo Superette's standout offerings is fresh, hand-rolled kimbap — a popular Korean dish featuring seasoned rice, vegetables and choice fillings like marinated meat or fish, all wrapped in dried seaweed and sliced for easy enjoyment. This kimbap, which actually uses quinoa in place of rice, comes from an L.A.-based chef Christina Ko, who is a close friend of James and Cindy.

Every Monday, Ko personally delivers freshly made kimbap to Yoboseyo Superette, providing a steady source of this delicious specialty for eager customers. Previously reliant on pop-up markets, Ko now has a consistent home for her creations, with Yoboseyo allowing her to connect with more of the community and share her unique flavors year-round. This is just one example of the many products from local businesses that James and Cindy have integrated into their store.

The design of the physical space within the store also serves as a testament to James and Cindy's determination to help small businesses. When designing the interior, the couple hired local artists to hand-paint the walls. The murals are designed to resonate with USC students, with images like the California poppy and a USC ballcap.

As for the menu, Yoboseyo Superette serves a variety of milk and fruit tea beverages. Some of the store's signature drinks include the Jasmine White Grape, Oolong Milk Tea and Tiger Milk, but its most popular drink is its Blueberry Matcha Latte with boba, which uses the same recipe as sister store Cafe Dulce to create a refreshing, sweet boba drink. The range of menu items offers something for everyone. The couple prides themselves on taking immense care in preparing the milk teas.

"I think the reason why our milk teas stand out is we actually use coffee equipment to brew the tea into the milk," James said.

The store is looking to continue to expand its menu in the future, although the couple discussed that one of the biggest challenges with opening the new store has been the availability of quality boba. Since Yoboseyo Superette sources its boba from Fanale, the only manufactured boba tea supplier in the United States, the supply is more limited, making it harder to obtain. In spite of this challenge, James and Cindy said they will remain committed to serving high-quality drinks made with local ingredients.

"We're really trying to put something on there that we'll be able to stand behind," James said.

While the couple is not opposed to the idea, they currently are not planning on opening any additional stores. Rather, they are focused on cultivating a tight-knit community at their existing locations.

With a mission to support small businesses, cultivate community and provide a space for students to relax and connect, Yoboseyo Superette is poised to become a neighborhood staple. By blending quality drinks, local products and a welcoming atmosphere, Yoboseyo Superette offers the USC community so much more than just a place to grab a quick drink.

Abby Weiland is an assistant editor for the Daily Trojan Magazine. Weiland is a freshman majoring in American popular culture.

FALL 2024 EDITORS

Editor-in-Chief
KIMBERLY AGUIRRE
Magazine Editor
SASHA RYU
Assistant Magazine Editors
MIRANDA HUANG
ALEXA RUBINSTEIN
ABBY WEILAND
Art & Design Director
VIVIENNE TRAN
Diversity, Equity & Inclusion Director
PEYTON DACY

Chief Copy Editors
DEON BOTSHEKAN
FIONA FEINGOLD
Managing Editors
STEFANO FENDRICH
ALIA YEE NOLL
ALEXA AVILA
BIANCA ARZÁN MONTAÑEZ
NATHAN ELIAS
Photo Editor
HENRY KOFMAN

Special thanks to Jake Berg, Henry Kofman and Nathan Elias for their contributions to this month's edition of the Daily Trojan Magazine.

Wesley Chen / Daily Trojan file photo

DT
mag
EST. 2023